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Citi India CEO: India's AI Script must Change
SMART INVESTING ▸▸ 12

IndiGo, Air India to Shift Flights to Navi Mum Airport
BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ▸▸ 4

UK PM Seeks Debate on Free Worker Movement in EU
AROUND THE WORLD ▸▸ 15

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PUREPOLITICS

Centre Rushes RAF to Arunachal Pradesh as Protests Turn Violent

The Centre dispatched two Rapid Action Force companies of CRPF to the affected areas after protests turned violent in Arunachal Pradesh's Pasighat against the proposed 11,200 MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project. Prohibitory orders have been imposed in some parts. **Bikash Singh** reports. ▸▸ 2

■ NIA Court in J&K Acquits Five Booked under UAPA ▸▸ 2

■ NRC Logjam Delays Assam SIR, No Clarity on Timeline ▸▸ 3

ET CORNER OFFICE CONVERSATION

Anirban Chowdhury talks to Emergent's Mukund Jha about the future of coding, AI-run businesses, the threat to SaaS, the economics of AI unicorns and the lessons from Dunzo's collapse in this episode of

Available on EconomicTimes.com/podcast, Amazon Prime Music, Apple Podcasts, JioSaavn *and* Spotify.

BANKS & FIN COS, IT AND PHARMA FIRMS AMONG LAGGARDS

Double-digit Growth Seen on Corporate Scoreboard in Q2

India Inc's revenue grows at nine-quarter high of 22%; profit expands at 28% YoY

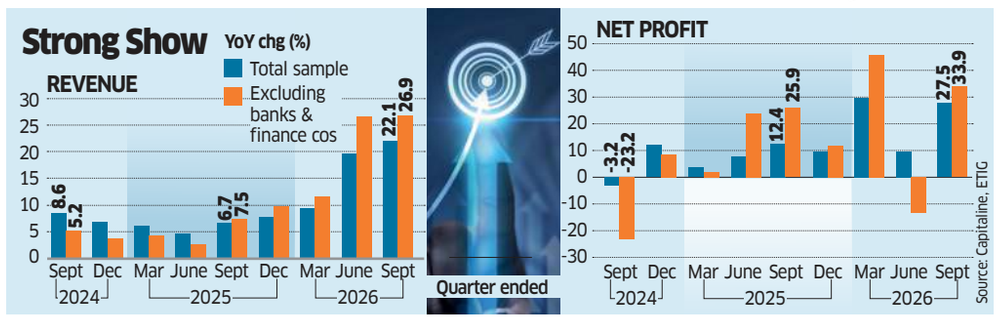
Ranjit Shinde

Mumbai: The early trend in September quarter earnings reflects double-digit growth in aggregate revenue and net profit, along expected lines, based on a strong showing by select companies in sectors such as capital goods, metals, consumer durables, chemicals and auto ancillaries.

On the other hand, sectors including banking and finance, information technology (IT) and pharmaceuticals showed deceleration in year-on-year growth compared with June quarter numbers.

For a common sample of 357 companies that have declared September quarter numbers so far, revenue grew at a nine-quarter high of 22.1% year-on-year while net profit expansion at 27.5% was faster than the 9.7% advance in the June quarter.

Support from Low Base ▸▸ 5



Indian Stocks Still Costlier vs EM Peers

India's equity valuations are at their lowest levels in six years but remain more expensive than their EM peers for foreign investors, reports **Ravindra Sonawane**. ▸▸ 11

G-sec Yields Near '23 Peak, may Hit 7.75%

India's benchmark 10-year govt bond yield is headed toward 2022-23 levels, with traders warning it could hit 7.75% by December. **Rozebud Gonsalves** reports. ▸▸ 12

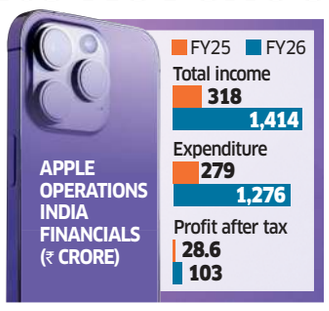
POSTS ₹650 CR FROM SOFTWARE BIZ IN FY26

Apple Ops India's Code Compiles into Revenue

Signals a shift beyond local mfg with country poised to be among co's global engg hubs

Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Apple has begun reporting revenue from software development in the country, generating ₹650 crore in FY26 through its recently established subsidiary Apple Operations India as the US major expands into technology research and development and global support operations beyond its local manufacturing footprint.



Mfg Support, Project Management ▸▸ 5

DEAL MAY VALUE PARENT CO AT AROUND ₹3KCR

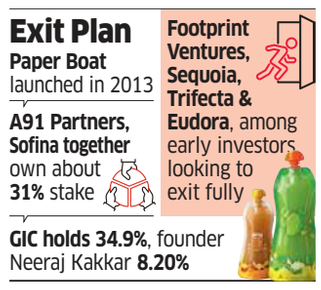
360 ONE, TR Cap Eye Stake of Paper Boat Early Backers

Reghu Balakrishnan & Ratna Bhushan

Mumbai | Delhi: Private equity firms 360 ONE and TR Capital are among potential buyers in talks to acquire about 20-22% stake held by early investors in the company that owns Paper Boat brand of traditional Indian beverages, multiple people aware of the development told ET.

The deal is likely to value the target company, Hector Beverages, around ₹2,700-3,000 crore, they added.

Existing investors, including A91 Partners, which have a 13.43% stake, and Sofina, with an 18% holding, are in discussions to partially exit their investments.



Cleaning Up Cap Table ▸▸ 5

ET INTERVIEW

PATRICE CAINE
CEO, THALES GROUP

Indian Capabilities will Help Develop Next-Gen Weapons

French co to increase India sourcing; goods, services worth €1.2b procured in past 5 yrs

Manu Pubby

New Delhi: Thales is looking to develop next-generation weapon systems with Indian suppliers and partners, group chief executive officer Patrice Caine said in an interview.

The €22 billion French aerospace and defence giant plans to increase sourcing of products and services from India that's exceeded €1.2 billion in the past five years, he said.

There's a significant opportunity for collaboration with Indian space launch companies as well, given the global shortage that's likely in 2029 when SpaceX rockets will no longer be available to other customers, he told **ET**.

On co-development, the executive said Indian suppliers and partners are firmly part of the group's growth strategy.

"When I look at our radars, missiles, and electronic warfare equipment, it is clear that India has the capabilities to contribute to the development of next-generation systems," Caine said. "We can build on these capabilities in India and, in fact, we started selecting Indian suppliers several years ago."

The Thales Group is one of the world's largest aerospace and defence manufacturers, with products spanning the air, land, ground, cybersecurity and space domains, including significant work shares in major weapon systems such as Rafale fighter jets.

Transfer of Design Authority ▸▸ 5

As we're involved in satellites, there's a natural potential complementarity for us to turn to Indian launch service companies

DPDP DEADLINE VS ROGUE AGENTS

AI Exposes Data Law Blindspots

Ahead of the May 2028 deadline for DPDP law enforcement, AI-led risks are creating tension over what compliance could look like. **Himanshi Lohchab** & **Tanya Pandey** report. ▸▸ 14

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Mysore Road: 9900030620
Sundaram Toyota
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Nandi Toyota
Bangalore: *[Banashankari, Banaswadi, Bannerghatta, Bommanahalli, Whitefield]: 7022340713*
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Shodha Toyota
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PROTESTS AGAINST PROPOSED 11,200-MW SIANG UPPER MULTIPURPOSE PROJECT

Centre Rushes RAF Cos to Violence-Hit Arunachal

Prohibitory orders imposed; 15 held, more people could be arrested

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: After violent protests in Pasighat against the proposed 11,200-MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, the Centre dispatched two Rapid Action Force (RAF) companies of CRPF to Arunachal Pradesh, officials said on Sunday.

The violence, which started on Friday in East Siang district, continued until Saturday morning. Houses of MLAs Ninong Ering and Oni Panyang, as well as state BJP chief Kaling Moyong, were attacked and vandalised. A mob torched an NHPC office and a police station.

Arunachal Pradesh Police has imposed prohibitory orders in the violence-affected areas.

Nearly 40 security personnel injured in the violence: Police

The East Siang district administration has imposed prohibitory orders across Pasighat, Mebo and Ruksin to prevent further violence and maintain public order. The restrictions were imposed following a report from the superintendent of police, indicating an imminent threat to law and order.

Inspector general of police, central range, Hibu Tamang appealed to the public to maintain peace and ensure that protests are peaceful. Tamang informed that nine police vehicles were damaged in the violence.

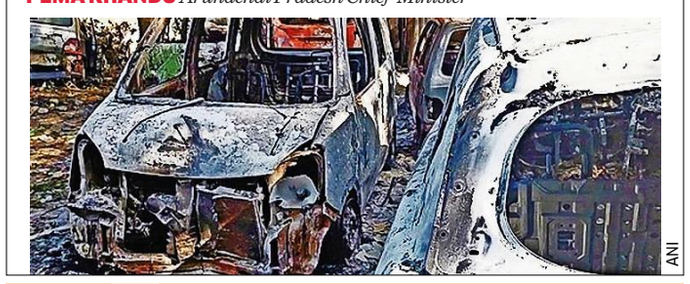
Police said that around 15 people were held in connection with the violence, adding that more individuals could be arrested.

The police said that nearly 40 security personnel were injured in the violence. "Some protesters were found to be in an inebriated condition and carrying bottles of alcohol," a police source said.

Arunachal Pradesh CM Pema khandu posted on X: "Misinformation and misconceptions surrounding the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project are creating apprehensions among our people. Bridging this information gap through facts, transparency and open dialogue is essential."

Misinformation, misconceptions surrounding Siang Upper Multipurpose Project are creating apprehensions among our people. Bridging this information gap through facts, transparency and open dialogue is essential

PEMA KHANDU *Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister*



ANI

Oppn Spreading Fake Narrative Over Hydel Project in Raigad: Fadnavis

MUMBAI: Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday accused the Opposition of creating a fake narrative about a proposed hydropower project in Raigad district, asserting that the unit will produce clean energy and help meet peak electricity demand. The project, proposed in Karjat tehsil, is the Saidongar-1 Pumped Storage Project, a 3,000 MW hydro-energy initiative. It is expected to contribute to grid reliability and energy security in the state and other regions. It envisages an investment of ₹13,505 crore. – PTI

38 TEAMS STRIKE 38 LOCATIONS ACROSS ASSAM, MIZORAM AND MANIPUR

Op Trident Delivers Blow to 'Death Triangle' Drug Cartel

Network involved in trafficking narcotics across the borders of India, Myanmar, Bangladesh

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: In a major blow to drug traffickers, Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) launched 'Operation Trident', with 38 teams striking 38 locations simultaneously across Assam, Mizoram and Manipur and arresting 18 people.

The network that was targeted trafficked narcotics across the borders of India, Myanmar and Bangladesh through the Death Triangle Corridor. Investigations exposed nearly ₹100 crore in illicit hawala transactions linked to the network, prompting joint action by Enforcement Directorate and freezing of illegally acquired properties, according to NCB. Around 1,424 bank accounts have been frozen.

In a post on X, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said "Modi government's lethal blows against drugs continue... Our agencies launched a barrage of simultaneous crackdowns across 38 locations in Assam, Mizoram and Manipur on October 23, smashing an international narco-cartel. The operation revealed ₹100 crore worth of hawala transactions, froze 1,424 bank accounts, attached properties worth ₹17.82 crore, seized 500 detonators and ₹12 lakh in cash, and led to the arrest of 18 people."

"The offensive attests to India's Himalayan resolve to realise the mission of eradicating every drug network by December 31, 2029. India will hammer until the last nail is driven into the coffin of drug cartels. Heartiest congratulations to the anti-narcotics team comprising central agencies, and police forces of the three states," he said.

NCB's 'Operation Trident' was launched in the early hours of October 23 along with the Mizoram Police and Enforcement Directorate.

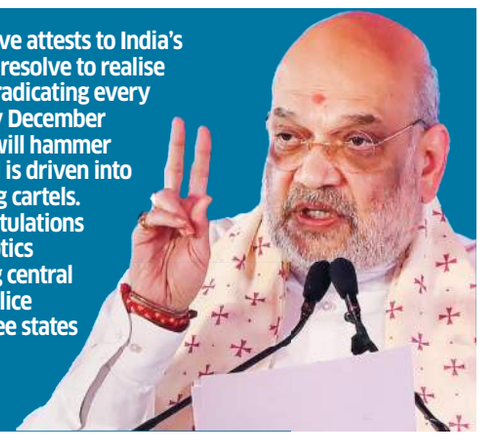
Thirty-eight multi-agency composite teams were mobilised concurrently across 38 pre-identified locations spanning Assam, Mizoram and Manipur. The coordinated strikes extensively covered key urban hubs and sensitive border corridors, including Aizawl, Champhai and the strategic Indo-Myanmar border, the trading town of Zokhawthar in Mizoram, alongside linked operative bases in Churachandpur, Manipur, and Cachar in the Assam transit corridor.

The multi-state operation led to the unravelling of a syndicate led by Myanmar-based kingpin Thangcintuang, alias Chintuang alias Tluanga, wanted in over 10 NDPS cases across NCB, Champhai Police and Mizoram Excise. The syndicate had orchestrated the cross-border routing of methamphetamine and heroin across the Myanmar-Mizoram-Manipur- Assam-Tripura corridor into mainland India and Bangladesh. He was arrested from Delhi following intensive inter-state surveillance, intelligence development, and sustained follow-up operations.

Vungkhanthawna, a key facilitator and close associate who coordinated the movement and delivery of Myanmar-origin consignments, was arrested and subsequently detained under the stringent The Prevention of Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act.

The offensive attests to India's Himalayan resolve to realise the mission of eradicating every drug network by December 31, 2029. India will hammer until the last nail is driven into the coffin of drug cartels. Heartiest congratulations to the anti-narcotics team comprising central agencies, and police forces of the three states

Amit Shah
Home Minister



DRUG SEIZURE CASE

Accused Escapes from Raj Police Lock-up, 2 Cops Suspended

JAIPUR: An accused arrested in connection with the seizure of narcotics worth around ₹1.30 crore escaped from a police lock-up in Rajasthan's Dholpur district **after breaking a window** on Sunday, officials said. The accused, Srinivasan T (45), a resident of Andhra Pradesh, was on police remand at Dehli police station when he escaped between 3 am and 6 am on Sunday, police said. Constables Vishnu and Jogesh were on duty at the time of the incident. The escape came to light early Sunday morning when constable Manoj checked the lock-up and found Srinivasan missing. He immediately informed Station House Officer Shaitan Singh. – PTI

PTI

SIGNIFICANT STEP

Manipur CM Visits Designated Camp of Militants in Kangpokpi Dist

As long as gun culture exists, state cannot achieve lasting peace: Khemchand Singh

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: In a most significant and historic move, Manipur chief minister Y Khemchand Singh on Sunday visited Sinai Camp, a designated shelter for militants under the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement in Kangpokpi district, according to an official statement.

The Sinai camp was recently disarmed and taken over by CRPF following joint operations by its CoBRA unit, Manipur Police and other security agencies in the aftermath of the recent killing of three firewood collectors near Nongshum in Imphal East district. During the operation, 17 individuals impersonating registered SoO cadres using false identities were found at the camp. The camp was supposed to house about 150 cadres.

Sinai camp disarmed and taken over by CRPF after jt ops by its CoBRA unit, police & other agencies

After his arrival at the camp, the CM said that the state could not achieve lasting peace as long as "gun culture" persisted. While interacting with senior security officers, he maintained that due care must be taken to ensure that innocent civilians were not affected by combing operations.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Mercedes Driven by Judge's Minor Son Kills Scooter Rider in Keralam

KOCHI: A 54-year-old man died after his two-wheeler was hit by a Mercedes-Benz car allegedly driven by the minor son of an additional sessions judge in the early hours of Sunday, police said. The accident occurred near Cheranelloor between 2 am and 3 am, police said. A case has been registered under section 106 of the BNS (causing death by negligence). The minor was later released on bail in accordance with the provisions of the Juvenile Justice Act, police said. The investigation is underway, and a decision on whether to book the boy's father, in whose name the car is registered, will be taken later, police said. **Keralam minister Ramesh Chennithala said the victim's family need not worry about the course of the investigation, asserting that strict action would be taken against those who run over or kill people with their vehicles.** Earlier in the day, the deceased man's niece told reporters that her uncle ran a food stall to earn a living and was returning home when the accident occurred. **The woman alleged that the judge spoke to her disrespectfully at the police station when she questioned why his minor son had been allowed to drive the car.**

Decision on whether to book boy's father, in whose name the car is registered, will be taken later: Police

Dhanush Fan Club and Political Buzz

CHENNAI: Actor Dhanush on Sunday met members of the women's wing of his restructured fan club at a private college here, posing for photographs with hundreds of supporters and presenting them with a silver lamp as a return gift. The meeting comes shortly after the actor reorganised his fan network, formerly Dhanush Narpani Mandram, into a welfare movement named 'Dhanush Narpani Iyakkam'. Dhanush has not officially announced any political ambitions. However, the restructuring and the introduction of a new official logo have sparked speculation in Tamil Nadu about a possible entry into politics. – PTI

Mumbai Cops Foil Protest Bid; 140 Detained

MUMBAI: Mumbai Police on Sunday took nearly 140 people in preventive custody, foiling their plan to participate in separate protests at Shivaji Park and Chaityabhoomi allegedly organised without permission, officials said. Approximately 120 individuals assembled at **Shivaji Park for an unauthorised 'Adivasi Gen Z' protest** were rounded up and taken to the local police station. In a separate action nearby, police detained 20 to 25 people gathered at **Chaityabhoomi in Dadar for an unauthorised candle march**. Chaityabhoomi is the cremation site of BR Ambedkar, the chief architect of the Indian Constitution. – PTI

FILE PHOTO

MANN KI BAAT

Buy Local & Indigenous Products: PM's Appeal

'Mann Ki Baat is, for me, nothing less than a pilgrimage'

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: With the festive season in full swing, Prime Minister Narendra Modi reiterated his appeal to Indians to go "vocal for local" and buy indigenous products to help the economy and the MSME sector. In his monthly 'Mann ki Baat' address on Sunday, he also paid tributes to Rishi Valmiki, whose Jayanti falls on Monday, and mentioned Ayodhya's Ram temple.

In his 139th address, the PM said that the programme that began on Dussehra 12 years ago is an auspicious thing for him. "Our country has a long-standing tradition of teerth yatra. 'Mann Ki Baat' is, for me, nothing less than a pilgrimage — a journey to closely understand the efforts of our people and to salute their contributions," he said.

The prime minister once again stressed the need to buy Made in India products to help Indian artisans and manufacturers.

As this movement (Vocal for Local) gains momentum, the dream of Aatmanirbhar Bharat will be realised all the faster. For that, I personally urge you to prioritise and highlight products crafted by local artisans

NARENDRA MODI *Prime Minister*

"During the festive season, we often buy many things for our families and loved ones. This time too, prioritise products made by local artisans when you shop; your purchases will boost their morale. This sense of affection will further strengthen the 'Vocal for Local' movement. As this movement gains momentum, the dream of 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat' will be realised all the faster. For that, I personally urge you to prioritise and highlight products crafted by local artisans," he said.

The PM also emphasised cleanliness during festivals, not just on Diwali but also Chhath, during which prayers are performed near water bodies.

Spl NIA Court in J&K Acquits Five Booked & Jailed Under UAPA

CASE: Grenade blast outside Kashmir University in 2019

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: A special NIA court in Kashmir has acquitted five persons booked under UAPA and jailed in connection with a grenade blast outside Kashmir University in 2019.

Special NIA judge Manjeet Rai said: "The difficulty of the prosecution is not merely one of defective investigation, it is the total absence of legally admissible evidence connecting the accused with the occurrence."

The case pertains to a low intensity blast near Sir Syed gate of Kashmir University in November 2019, in which four civilians sustained injuries. The accused, who have been acquitted now are Naseer Ahmad Mir, Umer Hamid Sheikh, Ajaz Ahmad Sheikh, Imtiyaz Ahmad Chikla and Sahil Farooq Gojri — all residents of Srinagar.

They were booked under sections 307, 120 (B) of IPC, 3-4 of Explosive Substance Act and sections 16 and 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. Police had claimed that the accused were in touch with a Jaish-e-Mohammed member, Burhan Bashir of Tral, who was killed in an operation in January 2020. They were represented by Mir Urfi Mir, MA Pandit and Associates, Waheed Ahmad Dar, Aqib Farooq and Zia ul Rehman.

"The court is conscious that the occurrence is a grave one...but the gravity of crime cannot dilute the standard of proof required to convict a person and the court of law cannot convict an accused on the strength of statements which the law expressly forbids it from receiving," read the order.

The court indicated that the circumstances concerned "must or should" and not "maybe" established. The court said there is not only a grammatical but a legal distinction between "may be proved and must be or should be proved." "When the prosecution evidence is examined dehors the lapses in investigation, what remains is the proof of an explosion and injuries and nothing more," read the order announced on October 22. "The submission that conspiracies are hatched in secrecy also does not relieve the prosecution of the burden of proving by admissible evidence, the circumstances from which the agreement is sought to be inferred."

Difficulty of the prosecution is not merely one of defective investigation, it is total absence of legally admissible evidence connecting accused with the occurrence

MANJEET RAI *Special NIA Judge*

FILE PHOTO

No Permanent Split of Fighter Assets: IAF Chief

Theaterisation must address security needs: AP Singh

Press Trust Of India

New Delhi: In his first comprehensive articulation on the theaterisation plan, Chief of Air Staff AP Singh said on Sunday that the Indian Air Force is not in favour of permanently splitting fighter assets geographically, advocating instead for a tailored structure built around India's specific security requirements rather than replicating foreign models.

In an interview to PTI, he said the guiding principle for theaterisation should be "centralised control" where necessary and "decentralised execution" where appropriate as he cited ongoing conflicts in various geographies to assert that air power can decisively shape military outcomes.

Detractors Trying to Establish '₹500 cr' Clip is Fake: Jarange

JALNA: All efforts are underway to establish that the '₹500 crore' audio clip released by him was fake, Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange said here on Sunday. **He also said Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut had no link to the clip.** The audio clip, released by Jarange on Thursday, contained a purported conversation between BJP functionaries about the quota activist being paid ₹500 crore through Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde, son of deputy CM Eknath Shinde. – PTI

ED Cites Notebook Seized From Residence of Vijayan's Daughter

CMRL-EXALOGIC CASE

Dubai ledger records AED 349K received by associate, details AED 146.6K in transfers

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: A handwritten notebook cited by Enforcement Directorate, in a letter written to Kerala Police, in its Dubai money-trail allegations records total deposits, a transfer to an associate and an account balance that differ by just two dirhams, people in the know told **ET**.

The notebook was seized on May 27, 2026, from the residence of T Veena, daughter of former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, in the CMRL-Exalogic alleged money laundering case. One page records a "total deposit" of AED 2,82,600 and a transfer of AED 1,46,600 to Faijaz VP, whom ED describes as a UAE-based associate.

It gives an account balance of AED 1,36,002 "as on 17/Sep/2024". Deducting the transfer from the deposit total yields AED 1,36,000, within AED 2 of the stated balance.

The same page carries the entries "Total sent from here — 85L" and "Total Faijaz received — 349K (AED)". The latter is roughly AED 2 lakh more than the transfer recorded on the page.

Both Vijayan and Veena have strongly denied the allegations, calling them fabricated

Agent sources said the records do not establish whether the two figures cover the same transactions, or how much of the ₹85 lakh went through hawala channels and how much through banks.

A second page lists "local transfers" of 94,100 and 52,500, followed by "total 1,46,600 transferred to Faijaz's account". It attributes the 52,500 to a "Mashreq Account of Faijaz", a bank account, and the 94,100 to an unspecified account. The currency is not stated on that page, the sources said.

In its 25-page letter to the Kerala DGP, ED said the notebook indicated hawala or illicit routing of Indian rupees converted into dirhams.

The Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau FIRs registered on October 12 describe the AED 1,46,600 transfer as having taken place in September 2024, according to published reports of FIRs. The ledger records September 17, 2024, as the date against which the balance and expenses were calculated. It does not state when the transfer was made.

Another page records expenses of AED 56,430.91 as of that date, "as per Faijaz", and AED 1,12,352.60 thereafter. The notebook gives total expenses of AED 1,68,782.59.

The ledger entries described by the sources do not name Vijayan or former minister PA Mohammed Riyas. ED's letter links the alleged transactions to Riyas through statements recorded on August 18 from Varish K and Shyjal K under Section 17 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. The letter says Veena told ED that entries naming Nikhil, Waris and Shaijal were written in March 2026 and related to a proposed business investment. It says she described Faijaz as a friend of about 10 years.

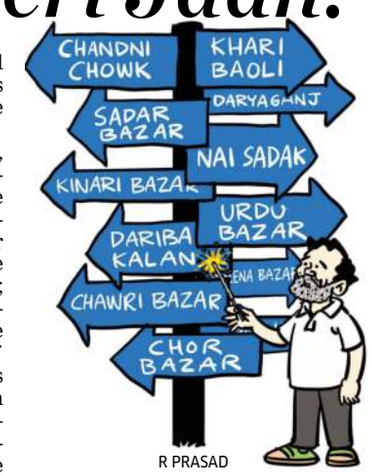
Ye Hai Bizness Meri Jaan!

Fearing disruptions in business during the peak Diwali season, traders have urged Rahul Gandhi to defer the INDIA bloc's November 1 rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan until after Bhai Dooj. Since he has avowed that he isn't "anti-business" but "anti-monopoly", the Leader of the Opposition may not disappoint the merchants of Delhi 6 and nearby areas.

Humouring the request could also help the Congress leader extend his vacation a bit. But if Gandhi decides to return to work on time — and there is no protest rally either — then what should he do? One of the options is to gain firsthand experience of the lanes, bylanes and sublanes of Chandni Chowk. The LoP would need a minimum of over a week to get a rough idea of the locality. Going around the marketplace will help him understand why the traders have asked for the postponement of the Opposition show of strength.

The labyrinthine crush of sellers, hawkers, vendors, shoppers, pedestrians, food lovers, pushcarts, cycle rickshaws, bikers and even idlers could be an epiphany — the shopkeeper isn't satisfied with daily sales as he contrasts his cashbox with the crowd; the buyer never feels the pain of spending because, by the end of the day, the body is so weary that one can think of nothing but rest; and the champions of wheels are just as much philosophers as they navigate through narrow passages, convinced they are on freeways. The idlers are always poetic.

This organised chaos also conveys a political message — never lose sight of the target despite pulls, pressures and obstacles, and there is order within disorder too.



R PRASAD

POLIMMICK

Pravir Kumar

This newspaper is published by Manjeet Singh Dhami from Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., Elixir Chancery Building, 1st, 2nd and 4th Floor, 135, Residency Road, Shanthala Nagar, Bengaluru – 560025 (Phones: Office: EPABX - 080- 42200000, Editorial: 080- 46787878) on behalf of Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., edited by Manu P Toms and printed by Sekar S at Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., The Times of India Press, No. 9/10/11-A, 4th Main, KIADB Bommasandra Industrial Area, Anekal Taluk, Bangalore - 560 099 (Ph : 080-22899999). Regd office: Dr. D.N. Road, Mumbai - 400 001. All rights reserved. Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission is prohibited. REGD. NO. CPMG/KA/GPO-31/200C3-05, **RNI NO.** 45467/85

CM THREATENS ACTION AGAINST FIRMS SIDELINING LOCALS IN RECRUITMENT

Kannadigas Supreme in Their Own State, DKS Warns IT Firms

Remarks come after video of a local woman surfaces alleging bias against Kannadigas

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar on Sunday warned IT companies of action if they were found discriminating against Kannadigas in recruitment, reigniting a politically sensitive debate over local employment that the state government had shelved two years ago.

In a post on X, Shivakumar said it was "disheartening" to hear complaints that Kannadigas were being denied job opportunities at Bengaluru's technology companies. He said the government was taking allegations that native Kannada speakers were being sidelined during recruitment seriously.

His remarks came after a video in which a young woman alleged that hiring managers were biased against Kannadigas at technology firms went viral on social media.

The clip sparked a wider online debate, with some alleging that recruiters from other states often preferred candidates from their own regions over local applicants.

"Kannadigas are supreme in their own state," Shivakumar said, adding that the government would not allow the rights, dignity and opportunities of Kannadigas to be ignored. "The world sees Bengaluru as India's technology capital, and we take immense pride in the talent, skills and capabilities of our Kannadigas. If it is found that any private institution has deliberately sidelined Kannadigas, the government will take appropriate action," he said.

Proposed Quota Bill

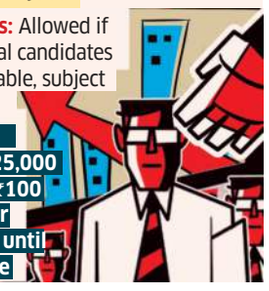
50% quota for locals in management jobs

75% quota for locals in non-management jobs

Local eligibility: Born in Karnataka, 15-year residency, or Kannada proficiency via a language test

Exemptions: Allowed if suitable local candidates are unavailable, subject to limits

Penalties: ₹10,000-25,000 fine, plus ₹100 per day for violations until compliance



The issue has brought the debate over local job quotas back into focus, nearly two years after the Siddaramaiah government put on hold a contentious bill mandating reservations for locals in private-sector employment following strong opposition from the technology industry and industry body Nasscom.

The proposed legislation sought to reserve 50% of management positions and 75% of non-management jobs for locals in industries, factories and other establishments across the state.

Nasscom had warned that such a move could adversely affect Karnataka's investment climate and prompt some companies to consider relocating.

The industry body noted that Karnataka contributes about 25% of India's technology output, is home to more than 11,000 startups and accounts for around 30% of the country's global capability centres (GCCs).

The debate resurfaced in December last year, when then CM Siddaramaiah again indicated that the government was exploring measures to increase employment opportunities for Kannadigas in the private sector.

NRC Logjam Delays SIR in Assam, No Clarity on Timeline

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Assam remains the only state to have gone to assembly polls in April without undergoing the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, with no clarity yet on when the exercise will be conducted as the creation of an Aadhaar-like data security regime for the National Register of Citizens (NRC) has missed its August-September deadline.

Instead of SIR, a Special Revision (SR) was conducted as illegal immigration from Bangladesh has long been a contentious issue in the state. On October 16 this year, Assam's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) announced the commencement of a Special Summary Revision (SSR) of electoral rolls. The draft electoral roll is scheduled to be published on November 12.

A senior Assam government official said, "There was a timeline to complete the creation of an Aadhaar-like data security regime for the NRC by August-September, but the process has not been completed. There is no clarity on when it would be finalised. Only after its completion can the SIR process be rolled out.

The RGI can notify the NRC only after the data security regime is in place."

On November 18, 2025, Assam CEO said the state's home department had informed the ECI that work on creating the data security regime for the NRC was underway and was likely to be completed by August 2026. The SIR of electoral rolls in Assam could be conducted once the process was completed, he said.

Both the BJP-led Assam government and the state CEO had separately informed the ECI in late 2025 that the SIR should be conducted only after the assembly elections and once the NRC was notified.

The NRC updation exercise was undertaken under the supervision of the Supreme Court to identify and exclude illegal immigrants from the register. The supplementary NRC list, published on August 31, 2019, found more than 31.1 million people eligible for inclusion in the register, while excluding over 1.9 million people.

The NRC updation process in Assam remains stalled years after the publication of the supplementary list, as rejection slips have yet to be issued to those excluded. These slips are necessary for them to challenge their exclusion before Foreigners Tribunals.

Kharge's Remark on Modi Sparks Row, BJP Hits Back

Our Political Bureau | PTI

Patna | New Delhi: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday sparked a controversy with his remarks "Modi ka baap bhi jayega", in response to an audience member's comment that "the PM would not go anywhere", during an event in Bihar.

Responding to Kharge's statement that the Congress will send those involved in carrying out alleged irregularities in the SIR process to jail, a person from the audience shouted, "As long as there is no rebellion, (PM Narendra) Modi won't go anywhere." The Congress president shot back, saying, "Modi ka baap bhi jayega" (Let alone Modi, even his father would go).

BJP and its allies condemned Kharge's remarks and rejected his allegations of electoral malpractice in Bihar. BJP leader Nitin Nabin in a post on X said, "The kind of indecent and unparliamentary language used today in Patna by Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge towards the country's PM Narendra Modiji reflects the Congress party's ideological bankruptcy."

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Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026

(₹ in Lakhs)

S. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended September 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter ended September 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	Half year ended September 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	Previous year ended March 31, 2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	6,38,198.97	5,22,386.55	12,37,394.76	21,61,427.76
2	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	1,15,430.41	72,889.12	2,21,829.03	3,47,404.56
3	Net Profit for the period before tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	1,15,430.41	72,889.12	2,21,829.03	3,47,404.56
4	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	85,768.99	56,087.03	1,65,364.28	2,64,125.43
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period {Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)}	Refer Note (ii)	Refer Note (ii)	Refer Note (ii)	Refer Note (ii)
6	Equity Share Capital	75,136.86	74,611.12	75,136.86	74,826.71
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet of the previous year	19,22,525.49*	16,42,175.12**	19,22,525.49*	19,22,525.49*
8	Securities Premium Account	5,73,291.23	5,40,899.20	5,73,291.23	5,54,034.57
9	Net worth (Refer Note iii)	21,12,236.23	17,93,647.20	21,12,236.23	19,62,694.85
10	Outstanding Debt	14,23,864.32	10,31,904.20	14,23,864.32	13,87,154.47
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	-	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio (Refer Note iii)	0.31	0.26	0.31	0.31
13	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - {(before and after exceptional item) (not annualised)}				
	1. Basic (after exceptional item):	11.44	7.52	22.07	35.40
	2. Diluted (after exceptional item):	11.30	7.48	21.81	35.01
	3. Basic (before exceptional item):	11.44	7.52	22.07	35.40
	4. Diluted (before exceptional item):	11.30	7.48	21.81	35.01
14	Capital redemption reserve	-	-	-	-
15	Debenture redemption reserve	-	-	-	-

Notes:

* As at March 31, 2026 ** As at March 31, 2025

(i) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter & half year ended Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter & half year ended Financial Results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com and of the Bank www.au.bank.in. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provide below.

(ii) Information related to the total comprehensive income and other comprehensive income are not furnished as Ind AS is not yet made applicable to Bank.

(iii) Information as required pursuant to Regulation 52(4) of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 Methodology for computation of the ratios is as follows :

Debt-Equity Ratio	Represents the Borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year / Sum of Capital and Reserves & Surplus.
Net worth	Calculated as per the Directions issued by the RBI to Small Finance Banks on Concentration Risk Management

Date : October 24, 2026

For AU Small Finance Bank Limited
Sanjay Agarwal
Founder, MD and CEO

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Watchmaker Jacob & Co, GB Realty Tie Up for Branded Hsg Project in Punjab

Faizan Haidar

New Delhi: Global luxury watch and jewellery brand Jacob & Co has tied up with Punjab-based real estate developer GB Realty for Punjab's first branded residences development and first such project in a tier-2 city in the country.

The company had acquired the 9-acre land for close to ₹550 crore in a local authority auction where it will develop five residential towers.

Earlier, Realty M3M India had tied up with Jacob & Co to develop a luxury branded residential project in Noida and Gurugram.

"The purchasing power of Chandigarh is better than some of the metro cities. A development of this scale will offer the buyers to select the brand they aspire," said Gurinder Bhatti, founder and managing director, GB Realty.

The group will have Salman Khan residences as well. While the entire project will be designed by Jacob & Co, two towers will be called Salman Khan residences and the remaining three will be called Jacob & Co residences. GB Realty plans to invest approximately ₹2,400-2,500 crore in the development.

Co had bought the 9-acre land for close to ₹550 cr in a local authority auction where it will develop five residential towers

The development is part of GB Realty's broader plan to invest over ₹5,000 crore over the next three years as it expands its luxury residential portfolio and enters new real estate segments and markets across North India. Over the next five years, the company aims to scale its cumulative investment to approximately ₹10,000 crore, with around ₹3,500 crore earmarked for luxury and ultra-luxury residential developments.

North India is turning into a hub for branded residences, with developers in Gurugram, Noida, Faridabad and even Chandigarh tying up with brands.

Experts said that sluggish sales in the past few months have led to these brand tie-ups, as developers feel branded projects will command a premium and help boost sales as well. Recently, Signature Global inked a pact with Italian lifestyle brand Tonino Lamborghini to develop a premium residential project in Sector 71, Gurugram.

Hospitality firms like Marriott have tied up with Whiteland Group, Taj has tied up with Gulshan Group, while Sarovar Portico has also tied up with Ace, The Element and Gaurs Group. Among the non-hospitality players, Elie Saab and Jacob & Co have tied up with M3M and Smartworld, while YOO has tied up with Dalcore.

FOCUS REMAINS ON SCALABILITY AND MARGINS

Consumer, Retail Deal Values Take a Hit as Investors Turn Cautious

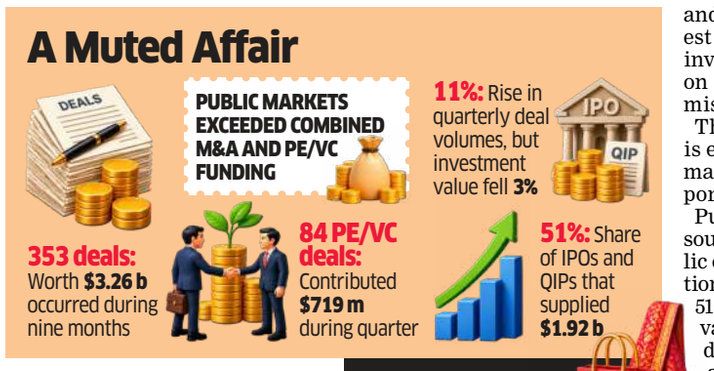
Transaction value falls 58% in Sept qtr; M&As for first 9 months also down 6% in volume terms

Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: India's consumer and retail deal value fell 58% year-on-year to $948 million in the September quarter, as fewer large transactions weighed on investment, with just two deals exceeding $100 million compared with five a year earlier, according to a Grant Thornton Bharat report.

In the first nine months of 2026, mergers and acquisitions (M&As) and private equity and venture capital (PE/VC) activity in the segment totalled 353 deals worth $3.26 billion, down 6% in volume and 53% in value from a year ago.

The decline suggests that investors are becoming more cautious, favouring brands with a clear proposition and path to profitability, rather than aggressive expansion. While dealmaking continued across consumer categories, fewer large deals and smaller funding rounds pulled down overall values.



"India's consumption story continues to attract investor interest, but capital is increasingly directed towards businesses with differentiated brands, strong category positioning and the ability to scale profitably," said Naveen Malpani, partner and consumer, retail and e-commerce industry leader at Grant Thornton Bharat.

PE/VC accounted for 84 of the quarter's 113 deals, worth $719 million, making it the largest contributor to dealmaking. While deal volume increased 11% quarter-on-quarter, investment value fell 3%, pointing to continued interest in consumer businesses but more measured capital deployment.

"Strong private equity activity relative to strategic M&A suggests that investors continue to see significant headroom for consumer businesses to expand market share, strengthen brands and build category leadership," said Malpani.

Personal care emerged as a bright spot, with investment value surging sixfold sequentially as investors backed premium beauty, wellness and direct-to-consumer brands. Jewellery, apparel and lifestyle also attracted interest across acquisitions, private investments and public markets, on the back of ongoing premiumisation trends.

The festive and wedding season is expected to help these sectors maintain this trajectory, the report said.

Public markets provided another source of capital, with initial public offerings and qualified institutional placements accounting for 51% of the quarter's overall deal value of $1.92 billion. This exceeded the combined value of M&A and PE/VC transactions, which stood at $948 million.

"The growing contribution of public markets highlights the expanding funding options available to established consumer businesses. As demand patterns evolve, the ability to build lasting consumer relationships and sustain growth will be critical to creating long-term value," Malpani said.

The demand outlook, however, may prove to become even more uneven, according to him, as weather-related disruptions and the potential impact of El Niño on agricultural output and rural incomes weigh on consumption in some categories.

IndiGo & Air India to Shift Some Flights to Navi Mumbai Airport

TERMINAL 1 REDEVELOPMENT To move 133 weekly flights mostly serving West Asian markets

Forum Gandhi

Mumbai: IndiGo and Air India Group will shift 133 weekly international departures from Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport to Navi Mumbai International Airport, with most of the flights serving destinations in West Asia, including Jeddah, Riyadh, Dammam and Doha, according to people familiar with the matter.

The move will shift nearly three million passengers a year to the new airport, accounting for about 60% of the annual capacity reduction of five million passengers planned at Mumbai airport for the redevelopment of Terminal 1, the people said. Capacity equivalent to about two million passengers a year remains to be addressed.

In statements on Sunday, IndiGo and Air India Group outlined plans to progressively move international services to the Navi Mumbai airport over the coming months. This will allow the airlines to maintain services while the redevelopment at Mumbai airport requires a reduction in operating capacity.

IndiGo will progressively transfer 12 daily international departures to the new airport, covering existing services to Bahrain, Riyadh, Dammam, Jeddah, Madinah, Kuwait, Ras Al Khaimah, Fujairah, Muscat, Dhaka and Jakarta. It also plans to introduce a daily service to Kathmandu, taking its international network at Navi Mumbai airport to 12 destinations between February and July 2027.

In a joint announcement, IndiGo and Adani Airports said they were in the "final stages of operationalising" the plan. IndiGo will also transfer the domestic connectivity required to support its international operations from Navi Mumbai airport. Final dates remain subject to project coordination and operating approvals.

Air India Group will shift seven daily departures, according to people familiar with the matter. Air India Express will begin operating four daily domestic flights from Navi Mumbai in December. It plans to introduce services to Kuwait, subject to approvals, and operate existing services to Oman from January 2027.

The airline will progressively transfer services to Jeddah, Riyadh, Dammam, Doha, Muscat and Sharjah, with the transition expected to be completed by the International Air Transport Association Northern Summer 2027 season, covering the March 28-October 30 period.

The shift comes as the Mumbai airport prepares to redevelop Terminal 1, which currently has capacity for about 15 million passengers annually. The rebuilt terminal is planned to handle 20 million passengers a year, with reopening targeted for March 2030. The airport operator has said airlines' historic slots will be restored after the terminal reopens. However, international airlines including Emirates and Air France-KLM have expressed reservations about moving capacity to the new airport, which is about 50 km away from the existing airport.

Discussions with other airlines are continuing, with a meeting scheduled for October 28 and further talks expected next month ahead of the November 4 deadline for filing summer-schedule slots. Akasa Air could also reach a decision on moving some operations to the Navi Mumbai airport soon, according to people in the know.

'NAINA to Create 15 Lakh Jobs'

ANI

MUMBAI: Maharashtra chief minister **Devendra Fadnavis** on Sunday said the proposed NAINA city near Navi Mumbai International Airport is expected to generate 1.5 million jobs. Describing NAINA, or Navi Mumbai Airport Influence Notified Area, as 'Third Mumbai', Fadnavis said planned urban centre would emerge as a major growth engine for Maharashtra over the next 50 years.

"Of the 15 lakh jobs expected to be generated, 5 lakh would be high-paying positions, while 10 lakh would be at basic-to-intermediate levels." he said at an event to launch development works in NAINA and inaugurate the Uran bypass road in Raigad district. – **PTI**

CO READIES PLAN TO PUSH GROWTH

'Lindt Misjudged How Customers Would Respond to Its Price Hikes'

Chairman Tanner's comments follow ouster of chief over concerns about performance

Reuters

Zurich: Lindt & Sprüngli has struggled because it misjudged how consumers would respond to price increases, the chair of the Swiss chocolate maker said, days after the company ousted its CEO over concerns about its performance.

In an interview with the NZZ am Sonntag newspaper, executive chairman Ernst Tanner said the firm, whose shares have tumbled more than 25% this year after recent outlook cuts, was largely suffering because it had misread the market in Germany.

"We misjudged how customers would respond to price increases. After cocoa prices reached historic highs from 2024 onwards, we wanted to pass on those additional costs. In doing so, we overestimated how much we could raise prices without hurting demand," he said. "For some consumers, our products clearly became too expensive in recent months."

For some consumers, our products clearly became too expensive in recent months

ERNST TANNER
Chairman, Lindt & Sprüngli

COMPANY PHOTO

"Lindt & Sprüngli as a whole, however, is not in crisis," Tanner added, arguing the company's shares are now undervalued. "In the Americas and the Far East, we'll achieve our growth targets of 6% to 8% this year as well."

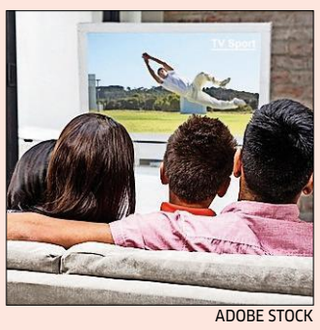
Tanner, 80, who was CEO from 1993 to 2016 and has been chairman for over three decades, rejected the suggestion that he should stand down, saying he had important work to do to get Lindt back on track.

"Once that's been achieved, I look forward to turning to the next phase of my life," he said.

Tanner said the company had already cut some prices as it seeks to lift sales volumes, and would have more scope to do so once cocoa prices returned to more normal levels. He said there would not be group-wide job cuts and that the firm wanted to keep growing.

Still, he said thrift was required and that bonuses would be affected in the Germany-Switzerland-Austria region as targets had been missed.

BARC Ratings Ban: GTPL Hathway Uses RPD Model to Publish Own Data


ADOBE STOCK

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: The suspension of Broadcast Audience Research Council (BARC) ratings has created an opening for cable and DTH operators to establish an alternative source of television viewership data under the ministry of information and broadcasting's TV ratings policy.

GTPL Hathway has made an early move by publishing data from its return-path-data (RPD)-based service, but the larger question is whether operator-led measurement can emerge as a credible industry-wide alternative.

Its viability will depend on the scale and representativeness of the data, sampling methodology and the ability to establish credibility among broadcasters and advertisers, industry sources said.

RPD captures viewing information from connected set-top boxes (STBs), tracking which channels households watch and for how long. Unlike BARC's panel-based system, which uses people meters and household-member information to estimate individual viewing, RPD typically records viewing at the household or device level. Its industry-wide relevance will depend on scale, geographical representation and methodological transparency.

GTPL is tracking viewing through 10,000 STBs and plans to expand to 50,000, working with TAM India to generate the data. Tata Play has also used RPD for years, primarily for internal content planning, according to industry sources. BARC earlier piloted RPD with Airtel Digital TV and DEN Networks, but the initiative failed to scale as operators sought compensation for sharing data and costs proved prohibitive.

Holcim Raises Guidance Again on Strong Demand

Company is ramping up use of alternative fuels, which is helping offset rising energy prices: CEO

Bloomberg

Holcim raised its full-year guidance for the second time this year after robust demand for more sustainable building materials saw third-quarter profit beat expectations.

The Swiss cement maker said Friday that it now sees full-year growth in recurring earnings before interest and taxes of up to 12%, from a previous estimate of 10%. Sales are forecast to increase by about 5%.

"This is a strong performance in the face of challenging markets," said RBC analyst Anthony Codling. Shares gained as much as 6%, the most since April.

The company's bullish outlook follows a 17% jump in recurring Ebit in the third quarter to 976 million Swiss francs ($1.2 billion), topping an estimate for 946.7 million francs. Increased customer demand and cost discipline helped drive the momentum, chief executive officer Miljan Gutovic said in a statement.

Holcim's outlook underscores how the company's suite of products with a lower carbon footprint have helped it avoid the growing pressure on the construction sector from higher energy costs. Infrastructure build in Europe is also accelerating and a surge in residential building permits are also seen underpinning its business.

Holcim is ramping up the usage of alternative fuels which is helping offset rising energy prices, Gutovic said. In September the company posted a record in the usage of alternative fuels in Europe, well above 70%, Gutovic said in an interview. He aims to turn that into 90% by 2030.

"We are less exposed to volatility and significant cost increases when it comes to energy prices as a result," he added.

'Godrej Prop Sales Bookings in FY27 May Beat Outlook with 22% Rise'

PTI

New Delhi: Realty firm Godrej Properties' sales bookings are expected to rise 22% this fiscal to a record ₹41,500 crore, beating annual guidance on strong demand for its housing properties, according to its chairperson Pirojsha Godrej.

Pirojsha Godrej noted that consumer demand has been "quite strong" in the company's new as well as ongoing residential projects across all markets where it has a presence. Even for the overall real estate market, he said the housing demand has "held up" and is "quite steady" despite the West Asia crisis causing global economic uncertainties.

Pirojsha said the company was on track to meet annual guidance or exceed it across all key metrics, including sales bookings, launches, collection of funds from customers, deliveries of projects and land acquisition.

In H2 of the financial year, we expect anywhere between ₹22,500 crore and ₹25,000 crore of sales, says chairperson

"In the second half of the financial year, we expect anywhere between ₹22,500 crore and ₹25,000 crore of sales. Even the bottom end of that gets us to past guidance, and the top end would be a good guidance beat and would get us to 20% year-on-year growth," he said.

In the last fiscal, Godrej Properties had sold properties worth ₹34,171 crore, and the company set a pre-sales or sales bookings guidance of ₹39,000 crore for the current FY27. Already, the company's sales bookings rose 7% to ₹16,659 crore in the first six months of this fiscal, a 7% increase from ₹15,587 crore in the year-ago period. "We are not seeing any of our own projects where we are disappointed with off-take or demand. I would say from a company perspective, demand has been quite strong," Pirojsha said.

AFP

In Character!

Performers dressed as characters from classic Chinese novels perform on Sunday in front of the Friendship Bridge and the Broken Bridge, which lead across the Yalu River into North Korea, the border city of Dandong, in China's northeastern Liaoning province.

Law Firms Make a Strong Case for Hiring Top Litigation Partners

IN SESSION Experienced partners with strong client relationships and specialised expertise in regulatory matters & disputes in demand

Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: Law firms are aggressively chasing top litigation talent amid increasing client demand around complex corporate disputes, tighter regulations and cross-border cases. They are not just seeking more lawyers, but experienced partners who can bring strong client relationships, specialised expertise and the ability to lead high-stakes disputes.

Demand spans experience in commercial and corporate disputes, including regulatory matters, insolvency, white-collar crime, investigations, sector-specific arbitration and complex shareholder disputes. Hiring has picked up not just in large firms but also at midsize practices and boutiques. Akshay Chudasama, managing partner of Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co's Mumbai office, said hiring was driven by client demand rather than the need to keep pace with competitors. Indian companies are increasingly facing disputes across jurisdictions, including Singapore and London, while foreign investors expect Indian lawyers to meet the standards they receive in their home markets. Regulators across sectors have also stepped up scrutiny, he said.

"Against that backdrop, we see the strongest growth in international and domestic arbitration, insolvency-related litigation, infrastructure and construction claims, shareholder and investor disputes, and regulatory and white-collar matters," said Chudasama. "Competition for partners is real, and we would not pretend otherwise, but a hire made purely to take share from a rival rarely holds up. For us, a lateral hire's cultural fit is paramount," he added.

In October, DSA Legal announced onboarding of Abhinit Das as a partner in its disputes practice. JSA Advocates & Solicitors strengthened its disputes team with lateral hiring of two partners, Ankit Jain and Ishan Gaur, at its New Delhi office.

Last month, DSK Legal hired Khushbu Chhajed as an associate partner in its dispute resolution practice; she previously partnered at MDP Legal.

"For clients, the stakes often extend beyond a court case's outcome," said Anand Desai, managing partner of law firm DSK Legal. "Disputes can affect deal timelines, capital allocation, business continuity, and corporate reputation, making experienced legal counsel a strategic requirement rather than merely a courtroom outcome," he added.

Experienced partners are particularly valuable because their expertise takes years to build. Over the past 12-18 months, law firms have increasingly sought not just strong general litigators but specialists in disputes seen as key growth areas.

"We are seeing significant interest in white-collar crime, sanctions, specialist IP disputes, international arbitration, regulatory investigations, and other niche disputes capabilities," said Premal Shah, partner at executive search firm FCL Search. As law firms compete for experienced disputes partners, they are looking beyond reputation to a candidate's ability to bring clients and teams with them, said Lee Ignatius, partner and co-founder of Vahura, another executive search firm.

Non-rainmaker litigation partners are available, but ones with a good book are rarer," said Rohit Jain, managing partner of law firm Singhania & Co. "There is a huge opportunity for rainmaker litigation partners to join midsize firms and enjoy better commercial terms with more flexibility and fulfilment."

Manufacturing Support and Project Management

▸▸ From Page 1

The new company, which began commercial operations in FY25, also provides manufacturing support, procurement assistance and global support services to Apple group companies. Revenue from manufacturing support nearly doubled to ₹520 crore in FY26 from ₹282 crore a year earlier, according to its latest regulatory filings.

A direct subsidiary of the global flagship Apple Inc, Apple Operations India's total revenue from these activities exceeded ₹1,400 crore in FY26, compared with ₹318 crore in FY25, while net profit nearly quadrupled to ₹103 crore from ₹28 crore, the company's filings made with the Registrar of Companies (RoC) showed.

"Apple Operations India's revenue growth appears to reflect a broader restructuring of Apple's Indian operations, rather than just organic expansion and manufacturing," said Mohit Yadav, founder of business intelligence firm AltInfo.

The emergence of software development and project-management services as revenue-generating activities in FY26 - after zero revenue from these segments the previous year - points to a widening of the Indian operation's role within Apple's global ecosystem, Yadav said.

"These transactions suggest Apple may be positioning Apple Operations India as a major global engineering and support hub," Yadav said.

on Broader Rejig

Apple Operations India's revenue growth appears to reflect a broader restructuring of Apple's Indian operations, rather than just organic expansion and manufacturing, says Mohit Yadav, founder of business intelligence firm AltInfo

The filings show that about 97% of Apple Operations India's business was undertaken for Apple's global operations, including Apple Operations International and Apple Inc. Its stated principal activities include manufacturing support, global support services, procurement support, software development and project management for group companies.

The development highlights the distinction between Apple's two key entities in India. Apple India is primarily responsible for domestic sales and marketing of the company's products. Apple Operations India provides services to the wider group globally. The manufacturing is done by contract manufacturers, and that value is not accounted for in the books of these two local Apple entities.

Apple India is owned by Ireland-based Apple Operations International Ltd. It reported a 31% year-on-year increase in revenue to ₹1,03,853 crore in FY26, while net profit rose 66% to ₹5,311 crore.

Apple India is also funding the expansion of its sister entity. According to the RoC filings, it extended a loan of ₹120 crore to Apple Operations India in FY26 to meet working-capital requirements. Total borrowings from Apple India stood at ₹340 crore as of March 2026. Apple Operations India has also entered into arrangements to sublease office premises from Apple India.

Support from Low Base

▸▸ From Page 1

A low base in the year-ago comparable quarter in terms of slower revenue and profit growth of 6.7% and 12.4%, in that order, also helped the trend for the latest quarter.

The total sample's operating margin contracted by 150 basis points year-on-year to 20.8%, reflecting weakness in the banking sector's profitability as net interest margins remained weak during the quarter. Excluding the lending sector, the sample's operating margin improved 20 basis points to 15.1%.

In addition, the sample's revenue and profit growth improved to 26.9% and 33.9%, respectively, after excluding banking and finance companies. The share of the lending sector in revenue and profit fell 34.8% and 54.6% from 37.3% and 56.8%, respectively, in the year-ago quarter.

The IT sector's share in revenue and net profit also dropped to 15.5% and 18.1% from 16.8% and 20.4% year-on-year, in that order. The sector has been reeling under pressure from elongated project execution cycles as clients take time to assess the impact of new technologies, especially artificial intelligence, on their businesses.

At the beginning of the results season, analysts anticipated double-digit aggregate revenue and net profit growth for the companies under their coverage, helped by broad-based momentum. "Expect 13 of 18 sectors to deliver double-digit sales growth, led by automobiles (around 29%), consumer discretionary (over 23%), industrials (over 22%) and nonbanking financial services (over 27%)," said Elara Securities (India).

Cleaning Up Cap Table

▸▸ From Page 1

Other early backers, such as Footprint Ventures, Sequoia Capital and angel investors, are looking to sell their entire stakes, said the people cited above.

The secondary stake sale is expected to be completed ahead of Hector Beverages' planned IPO in 2027. The exercise is aimed at cleaning up the company's cap table and consolidating shareholding among key large investors, the sources said. Avendus Capital is the advisor to the transaction. Early investors looking to exit include Footprint Ventures (3.08%), Sequoia Capital (2.19%), Eudora Ventures (1.22%), Mirabilis Investment Trust (0.61%), Trifecta Capital (0.14%) and Stride Ventures (0.08%).

Secondary stake sale is expected to be completed ahead of Hector Beverages' planned IPO in 2027

Lathe Investment Pte, a subsidiary and investment holding company of Singapore's sovereign wealth fund GIC Pte, is the company's largest shareholder, with a 34.97% stake. Founder Neeraj Kakkar holds 8.20%, according to Tracxn data. Hector Beverages also counts NR Narayana Murthy-backed Catamaran Ventures and Hillhouse Capital among its backers. Angel investors together hold about 3.1% stake. Noted angel investors are Kanwaljit Singh, M K Hamied and Samina Vaziralli of Cipla, and Nadir Burjorji Godrej. According to sources, several mid-market private equity firms, including Apax Partners and Creador, had explored the stake acquisition but did not pursue the transaction further.

Spokespeople at Hector Beverages and A91 declined to comment. Mails sent to Sofina, Sequoia Capital (Peak XV), Trifecta Capital, Stride Ventures, 360 ONE, and TR Capital remained unanswered till press time. Footprint Ventures, Eudora Ventures, and Mirabilis Investment could not be reached for their comments.

FINANCIALS

Hector Beverages was founded in 2009 by former Coca-Cola India executives Neeraj Kakkar and Neeraj Biyani. Two other founders — Suhas Misra and James Nuttall — left four-five years later. The company began by introducing Frissia protein drinks and Tzinga energy drinks, before it launched its flagship brand Paper Boat in 2013.

Transfer of Design Authority to India

▸▸ From Page 1

Caine didn't elaborate on negotiations that are underway with the defence ministry on the purchase of 114 additional Rafale jets, which will include significant technology transfer to India by leading manufacturers such as Thales, Dassault and Safran.

Speaking to **ET** ahead of a visit to India during which he will meet policy makers and customers, Caine said that makes "good business sense" to work with Indian partners, given the focus on quality and competitive pricing.

"We already have products in our supply chain that are manufactured in India and sold across global markets," he said. "The scale of this business is significant. Over the past five years, Thales has procured ₹1.2 billion worth of products and services from India. Looking ahead, I am confident that this will continue to grow." He cited the country's advantages.

"India has a strong industrial base, with companies that have a rich legacy and considerable expertise," Caine said. "This translates into quality, technical capability and competitiveness, which are precisely the attributes we look for when selecting long-term partners."

The Thales Group does not look at India just as a market for aerospace, defence, space, cyber and digital solutions but sees it as a critical hub for developing products for the global market with local engineering teams. He added that the company's strategy in India has been to bring in established technologies and enhance them for global markets.

"Defence is a good example," he said. "The need for defence equipment and capabilities in India is extremely significant, and we see strong potential not only to supply more products to India but also to Indianise them. This means going beyond transferring production to India to transferring design authority as well."

On opportunities in India besides the Rafale jets, Caine said that the Thales Group is focusing on cost-effective products that are suited for modern warfare, including smart rockets and short-range missiles like the Starstreak and the Lightweight Multirole Missile.

With regard to the space sector, Caine said Thales is looking to partner Indian companies with launch capabilities, pointing out that SpaceX will no longer be available for other customers by 2029, creating a potential shortage of satellite launchers.

GOOD BUSINESS

Caine said that it makes "good business sense" to work with Indian partners, given the focus on quality and competitive pricing

"For countries like India, mastering launchers clearly presents an opportunity to be much more in demand for satellite launches because of this gap," he said. "As Thales is involved in satellites, there is quite a natural potential complementarity for us to turn to Indian launch service companies."

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I, 14845708K, Hav/SHT, S Sivaprakasam of 443 (I) Supply Pl ASC changed my son's name S Pravaesh to Pravaesh S, for all purpose.

I, Syed Dada Peer S/o Syed Bashajan R/o Gangasandra Road Veerasagara, Veerasagara Rajeev Gandhi Nagara, Tumkur, PO-Someswarapuram, Dist-Tumakuru, Karnataka-572102, have changed my minor daughter's name from Salma Taj aged 16 years to Amreen forever.

I, Hemalatha Mohansankar D/o Mohansankar Thandavamoorthy, R/o F1204, 12th floor Tower F, Shriram Luxor, Hennur Main road, Chikkagubbi, B'luru-562149 have changed my name to Hemalatha Raghavendra for all purposes vide affidavit no IN-KA17852364273219Y

I, Kanajar Sivaram Deekshit alias K S Deekshit S/o Shivarama Nayak, R/o House No 2-55, Ganesh Nivas, B C Road, Bantakal Post, 92 Heroor, PO: Bhantakal, Dist: Udupi, Karnataka, 574115, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as K S Deekshit.

I, Prakash Kumar alias Prakash Dubey S/o Arvind Kumar Dubey R/o Villa no.10, Celebrities Golden Treasure, Bandenallasandra, Jigni, Anekal Taluk, Jigani, Bengaluru, Karnataka - 560105, have changed my name to "Prakash Dubey".

I, Shoab Qureshi S/o Mubarik Qureshi R/o #34 Royal Residency, Door no. A3, 2nd Floor, Emerald Layout 2nd Cross, RK Hegde Nagar- 560077, have changed my minor son's name from Mohammad Faiz to Mohammad Faiz Qureshi, age 6 years

I, hitherto known as H Prakash S/o Mangilal, R/O #54/1 2nd Cross, Saurashtrapet, Bangalore South, Dist: Bangalore, Karnataka-560053, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Prakash Chand.

I have changed my Name from(Old Name) Kavita Anil to (New Name) Kavita Rai. Affidavit no. 1755/2026 Place : Banglore

I YASMIN TAJ R@ No 55/A 2nd Cross Mysore Road Nayandahalli Bengaluru-39 has changed my name to Yasmeen Taj for all purposes.

I, S Geethamanjari W/o 14845708K, Hav/SHT, S Siva prakasam of 443 (I) Supply Pl ASC changed my name Sangita to Sangita Devi, for all Purpose.

I, 14845708K, Hav/SHT, S Sivaprakasam of 443 (I) Supply Pl ASC changed my son's name S Shailaesh to Shailaesh S, for all purpose.

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Gold, Silver Outlook Hinges on Fed as Oil Fuels Inflation Fears

PTI

New Delhi: Gold and silver are expected to face fresh headwinds next week as surging crude oil prices revive inflation concerns, while the US Federal Reserve's policy decision could determine whether bullion rates stabilise or extend their downward trend, analysts said.

The precious metals, already battered by elevated bond yields and a stronger dollar, will look to the Federal Reserve's October 27-28 meeting and its chair's commentary for signals on whether interest rates could stay higher for longer.

Pressure was evident in domestic markets, where gold futures for December delivery on MCX fell ₹5,768

The focus will also be on policy decisions from the European Central Bank and the Bank of Japan, along with US durable goods orders, consumer confidence, Personal Consumption Expenditures inflation and third-quarter GDP data. Eurozone inflation readings, developments around the US mid-term elections, Russia-Ukraine peace talks and the West Asia conflict will also remain on the radar, they added.

"The near-term outlook remains cautious, with gold likely to remain under pressure until there is greater clarity on the Federal Reserve's policy path. The upcoming decision could determine whether prices stabilise near current levels or extend their corrective trend," said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

The pressure was evident in domestic markets, where gold futures for December delivery on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX) fell ₹5,768, or nearly 4 per cent, over the past week to close at ₹1.42 lakh per 10 grams. Silver suffered a steeper decline, slipping below the Rs 2 lakh mark, shedding ₹15,087, or 7.14 per cent, to settle at ₹1.96 lakh per kg. "Gold continued its downward trend this week, declining more than 3 per cent on the MCX to trade near ₹1,42,800 per 10 grams as elevated bond yields continued to weigh on bullion," Trivedi said.

Higher US Treasury yields and a stronger dollar have curtailed recovery attempts in precious metals, leaving prices vulnerable to further selling pressure, he added. In international markets, Comex gold futures for the December delivery declined USD 173.2, or 4.14 per cent, over the past week, to close at USD 4,007.9 per ounce.

The yellow metal briefly slipped to USD 3,989 on Friday before recovering above the USD 4,000 level. Silver futures fell USD 3.35, or nearly 6 per cent, to settle at USD 53.95 per ounce.

"Gold futures continued their corrective momentum with prices globally falling below USD 4,000 per ounce, closing the week down by 4 per cent," said Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd.

Silver's decline reflected weakness across industrial metals and gold, alongside softer demand as industries explore alternatives or reduce their use of the white metal in response to high prices, he said.

NMDC Eyes Critical Minerals Across Four Continents

PTI

New Delhi: From South America in the west to Australia in the east, state-owned iron ore giant NMDC is scouting mining assets, including critical minerals, in four continents to meet the future needs of industries such as automotive, renewable energy, electronics, and steel, according to industry sources.

NMDC, which caters to India's one-fourth iron ore demand, has set a goal to earn at least 20% of revenues from sale of minerals other than the key steel making raw material.

Move aligns with govt initiatives aimed at securing long-term raw material supplies and reducing import dependency

Industry sources stated that the PSU is exploring lithium, copper, cobalt and rare earth blocks in Chile (South America), Australia, Africa, Brazil and parts of Asia. The company is also scouting for limestone mines, dolomite, coking coal and tungsten blocks in the UAE, Oman, Bhutan, and Australia, they said.

Acquiring these minerals will allow NMDC to cater to major industries in India on a growth trajectory, such as steel, auto, electronics, renewable energy, aerospace and defence, railway and metros, etc., sources said.

When asked for a comment, NMDC said, "Right now, we are a 99.9% iron ore company. We aim to help the growing industries in the country with the maximum of their mineral needs".

In an earlier interview with PTI, NMDC Chairman Amitava Mukherjee confirmed the company is working on strategies to diversify into selling other minerals as well. NMDC aims to be India's largest mineral mining company and earn at least 20% of revenue from minerals other than iron ore, he had said.

NMDC's expansion aligns directly with government initiatives aimed at securing long-term raw material supplies and reducing import dependency across economic sectors.

For the steel sector raw materials account for around 65-70% of steelmaking costs, as per the Ministry of Steel's draft Steel Policy Vision 2047, which aims to reduce import dependence through domestic mining, washery expansion, asset acquisition, long-term supply arrangements, and AI-based optimisation of coal blends.

The draft policy said India's objective of increasing the share of manufacturing in the economy, supported by initiatives such as Make in India, the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme, semiconductor manufacturing, defence indigenisation and the development of industrial corridors, is expected to significantly expand steel consumption in sectors such as automotive, engineering goods, capital goods, machinery, shipbuilding, renewable energy equipment and defence production.

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VITALS

FRENCH OPEN BADMINTON

'Fought for Every Point' Sindhu Loses in Final

Paris: Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu on Sunday said there is still plenty of room for improvement despite reaching another final of a Super 750 badminton tournament on Sunday. Sindhu put up a spirited fight before going down 21-16, 11-21, 12-21 to Olympic champion and world No 1 An Se Young of South Korea in the $950,000 French Open. "I'm happy with this, but there's a lot of space, a lot of room still there. So, I'm looking forward to it," said Sindhu. "I fought for every point, , I could win the first game, and I was happy about it," she said. **PTI**

PAES MISSING FOR AITA POLLS

Bhupathi and Sania File Nominations

New Delhi: Indian tennis greats Mahesh Bhupathi and Sania Mirza have filed nominations for the AITA SOM elections, seeking representation in the General Body (GB) and Executive Committee (EC), while the country's most successful player Leander Paes surprisingly did not file his papers for the November 7 polls. The absence of Paes, the only player featuring in Tier I in the 40-player roster, from the nominations list means that now he can't run for AITA Presidency. Headed by Paes himself, the Bengal Tennis Association (BTA) had publicly backed his candidature for the post of AITA president. **PTI**

PREMIER LEAGUE

More Misery for Man U, Lose 3-0 to Bournemouth

Liverpool beat Brighton & Hove Albion 2-0 on Sunday to grab their first home win of the Premier League season while Manchester United slumped to an embarrassing 3-0 defeat to Bournemouth that will heap further pressure on under-fire manager Michael Carrick, who benched captain Bruno Fernandes. The playmaker was left out after criticising Carrick's tactics in a 4-1 Champions League defeat to Italian side Como in midweek. Any hope that the move might inspire the rest of the side evaporated when Rayan scored in the 38th minute, with Marcus Tavernier adding a second before the break. **Reuters**

No Deleting this Dark History

1-1 in 3-Test series, SA & Oz return to Newlands—home of 2018 Sandpapergate—for decider starting tomorrow

SA v AUS
Newlands, Cape Town

FORM
WLWWW LWWLW

HEAD-TO-HEAD
Matches 104

SA	AUS	Draw
28	55	21

In South Africa 56

SA	AUS	Draw
17	30	9

Australia return to the scene of one of the darkest days in the country's cricket history when the series-deciding third Test against South Africa starts at Newlands on Tuesday.

The battle may be mental as much as one of skill for several of the Australian players, not least former captain Steve Smith, who was at the centre of the Sandpapergate ball-tampering scandal in 2018.

Current skipper Pat Cummins was part of that side, as were fellow seamer Josh Hazlewood and spinner Nathan Lyon, though they say they had no knowledge of the attempt to alter the condition of the ball with a piece of sandpaper.

Smith bore the brunt of the considerable fallout in Australia eight years ago and having not reached the heights he might have expected on this tour, averaging a little over 20 with the bat, he would see this as the perfect time to put that right.

There has so far been little chatter in South Africa about Sandpapergate but that could change at Newlands, where the first three days' ticket sales have been strong after sparse crowds at the first two Tests in Durban and Gqeberha.

"He'll be fine," Australia opener Travis Head said of Smith. "I think he showed that in 2019 in England. We support him. He's been through a lot in that space and handles it well. Sometimes it brings the best out of him, as we've seen in the past."

The series is level at 1-1 after big wins for both sides in the opening two games and Australia wicketkeeper Alex Carey told reporters on Sunday that it looked to be another good Test-match pitch.

"We are still a couple of days out but it looks another great surface," he said. "If you look back at Durban it was a five-day Test match and a great contest between bat and ball. The same in Port Elizabeth (Gqeberha) and this should be no different."

There has never been a Test match played at Newlands in October, and just three in November, all against Australia.

The tourists won the first two in 1902 and 1921, but the most recent November fixture was an eight-wicket victory for South Africa in 2011 when Australia were famously bowled out for 47 in their second innings.

South Africa will be without fast bowler Anrich Nortje, who injured his groin in the second Test. Captain Temba Bavuma said they would pick horses for courses in terms of his replacement.

"You've got guys like Gerald (Coetzee), Pato (Dane Paterson), as well as (Corbin) Bosch, and we have Sen (Senuran Muthusamy) as well, so the options are there," he said. "Whoever we decide, we'll be confident they form part of our best XI for the conditions." **Reuters**

He'll be fine. I think he showed that in 2019 in England. We support him. He's been through a lot in that space and handles it well. Sometimes it brings the best out of him, as we've seen in the past
OZ OPENER TRAVIS HEAD ON SMITH

BRANDED CONTENT INITIATIVE

Lord's Mark Industries Limited becomes Asia's first company to secure multiple US FDA registration for 200+ surgical and hygiene products; US exports to begin in December

Lord's Mark Industries Limited has become Asia's first company to secure US FDA registration for over 200 surgical, medical-care and hygiene products. The company plans to commence US exports in December 2026, marking a key milestone in its global expansion. With its Silvassa manufacturing capacity expansion completed ahead of schedule, Lord's Mark Industries Limited is strengthening production readiness for international markets. Its diversified portfolio spans orthopaedic supports, rehabilitation aids, mobility solutions and hygiene essentials, while the company explores South American markets, subject to applicable regulatory requirements.

The product portfolio includes Lord's Activeguard cervical-thoracic braces, soft cervical collars, cervical and lumbar supports, abdominal belts, rib belts, chest binders, clavicle braces, shoulder immobilisers, arm slings, wrist and forearm splints, finger splints, thumb spica splints, elbow supports, tennis elbow braces, knee caps, knee immobilisers, hinged knee braces, patellar supports, ankle braces, ankle binders, foot drop splints and bunion correctors. The range further includes compression stockings, varicose vein stockings, hernia belts, scrotal supports, pregnancy supports, pelvic binders, cervical traction kits, traction belts, walking sticks, walkers, wheelchairs, commode chairs, orthopaedic cushions, heel cups, silicone insoles and posture correctors.

The hygiene and medical-care range includes Lord's Joywipes disinfectant and cleansing wipes, Lord's Magic elastic adhesive bandages, IV Cannula Fixator elastic adhesive bandages, Lord's Wonder cotton crepe bandages, Lord's Confidence adult diapers and Safelite sanitary napkins. The portfolio also features disposable hot and cold gel packs and medical tourniquets. Together, these products provide a diversified base across orthopaedic support, rehabilitation, mobility, hygiene and medical-care essentials.

The expansion positions the company to explore opportunities in a substantial global healthcare market. According to Mordor Intelligence, the United States general surgical devices market is projected to grow from US$ 6.69 billion in 2025 to US$ 9.67 billion by 2031, registering a CAGR of 6.35 per cent. The South American general surgical devices market is projected to increase from US$ 1.37 billion in 2025 to US$ 2.19 billion by 2031, at a CAGR of 8.20 per cent. These broader market estimates highlight the potential opportunity, although the addressable market for the company will depend on individual product categories and applicable regulatory requirements.

Commenting on the development, Dr Sachidanand Upadhyay, Founder, Managing Director and CEO of Lord's Mark Industries Limited, said, "This certification proves the strong hold of our regulatory compliance team, our product quality and our vision to make India globally recognised. With over 200 products listed with the US FDA, we are strengthening our global presence. Early completion of our Silvassa expansion enhances export readiness, advancing our vision to position India as a globally recognised healthcare manufacturing hub through quality and regulatory compliance."

The company plans to leverage its expanded manufacturing capabilities to pursue partnerships with international distributors, healthcare suppliers and institutional buyers. While the United States will be the immediate export priority, South America offers a potential avenue for further expansion. Entry into individual markets will be subject to the applicable product-specific registration, import and distribution requirements.

Disclaimer: An initiative of Lord's Mark Industries Limited. BCCL does not endorse and is not responsible for the accuracy or completeness of the information contained herein. Readers should seek appropriate professional advice before taking any decision.

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Banks Seek Relief From Sustainable Lending Norms for FCNR(B) Loans

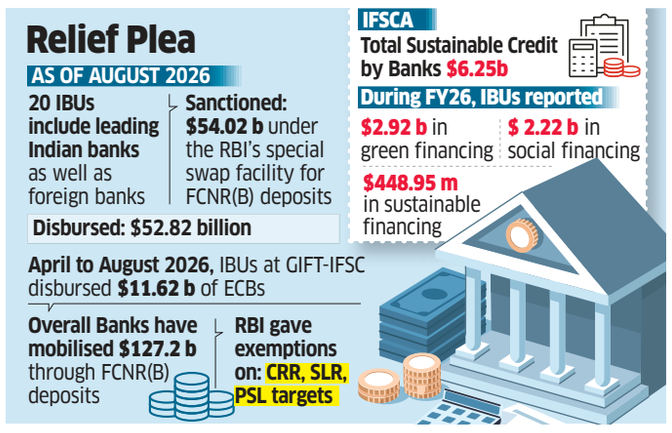
Lenders want exemption from the 5% mandate following a surge in GIFT City deposits

Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: Banks have reached out to the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) to exclude loans extended by international banking units (IBUs) against Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) [FCNR(B)] deposits from the computation of mandatory sustainable lending targets.

As per the existing regulations, IBUs are required to deploy an amount equivalent to at least 5% of their aggregate loans disbursed and specified investments made in the preceding financial year towards sustainable lending and investments.

"Some banks already had an informal discussion with IFSCA and now we plan to send a formal request after internal consultation with all stakeholders," said a bank executive, requesting anonymity. This comes as their has been a sharp increase in FCNR(B) mobilisation through GIFT City following the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) special foreign exchange swap facility introduced in June.



As per IFSCA data, till August 31, 20 IBUs at GIFT IFSC had sanctioned $54.02 billion under the RBI's FCNR(B) swap facility, of which $52.82 billion had been disbursed. "A special carve out can also be considered by the authority, as lenders will not be able to deploy these large amount given the limited investment avenues in the sector," said another bank executive, requesting anonymity.

"The RBI has already given special exemptions in case of priority sector lending and maintenance of cash reserve ratio (CRR) and statutory liquidity ratio (SLR) on fresh FCNR (B) deposits," he said adding that banks expect IFSCA to give a similar treatment.

In August, RBI said advances against fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNR (B), deposits with a minimum tenure of three years and a maximum tenure of five years, mobilised by banks under the scheme would be excluded from their adjusted net bank credit (ANBC) calculation.

In a statement in September, the finance ministry had noted that the performance of the IBUs under the FCNR(B) swap facility represents a significant demonstration of the ability of GIFT-IFSC to connect IBUs with global sources of foreign currency liquidity and efficiently channel international capital towards India.

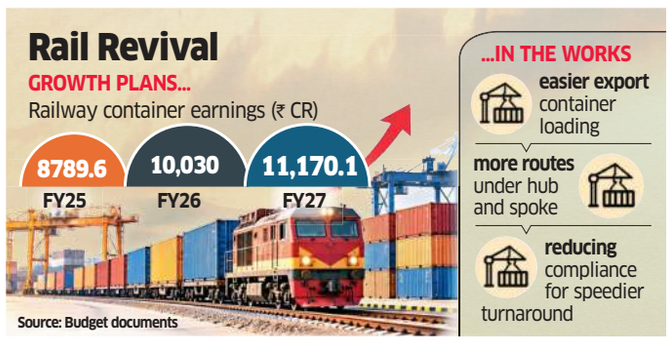
Earlier, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman had also asked banks to leverage the financial services ecosystem and institutional infrastructure available at GIFT-IFSC for effective implementation of the RBI's swap facilities for FCNR(B) deposits and External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs).

Railways Plans Container Transport Overhaul to Attract More Export Cargo

Twesh Mishra

New Delhi: Indian Railways is eyeing a complete revamp of container transport in bid to attract more export traffic, including reducing compliances such as weighing of containers, shorter rakes to carry higher value commodities, relaxed tariff regimes through telescopic benefits under the hub and spoke model, and privatised maintenance of flatbed wagons (used for container transport), among others.

"Containerised export traffic will be exempt from mandatory 100% weighment," a senior official told ET, adding this relaxation will be for certain commodities but random checks on 5% of rakes will be undertaken. Sector watchers say containers are weighed before (at depots) and after (at ports) their train journeys. The weighment checks by railways are an added compliance. Container operators will now need to just submit a copy of Verified Gross Mass as per guidelines issued by the Directorate General of Shipping.



In addition to lower compliance, the national transporter also plans introducing 'mini container rakes' of at least 25 wagons. There are currently around 750 container rakes (trains) on the Indian Railways of 45 wagons each. "Mini rakes are aimed at encouraging transport of higher value commodities in containers," the official said.

The Railways is also 'actively considering' industry proposals to allow private sector to maintain wagons, creating a new business opportunity for public-private partnerships (PPP). According to industry estimates, roughly 20% of all wagons are always in maintenance depots. Around 5% of the total freight tariff value is charged by the Indian Railways for maintaining container wagons.

"Multiple manufacturers and container freight train operators have made representations seeking permission to allow private maintenance of railway wagons," a second official said, deliberations are underway on financial terms to allow this. "Container train operators want a discount on freight value if they maintain wagons," the official said, adding the industry claims they will be able to offer speedier turnaround times.

Besides these measures, Indian Railways also plans increasing the number of routes where hub and spoke terminals will be present. This will allow freight train operators to consolidate containers from multiple locations and move them on the Indian Railways while retaining the benefit of charges eligible for long distance cargo transport, instead of having to pay higher short distance rates that accrue if cargo were to be re-booked at the hub-points.

Peak Power Demand Falls As Cooling Needs Ease

Shilpa Samant

New Delhi: India's peak power demand has eased to around 234 GW after remaining above 250 GW for much of the first half of October, as cooling and irrigation requirements begin to decline with the onset of cooler weather and rainfall in many parts of the country.

The fall comes after an unusually strong power demand in September and October, when consumption remained elevated amid below-normal monsoon rainfall. Peak demand touched 260 GW on October 5, the highest ever recorded for the month, and remained close to summer levels until October 15. This demand had reached 250 GW on October 15, with only a few days in the first half of the month seeing levels below 240 GW.

Fall comes after strong power demand in September and October, amid poor monsoon

A government official had told **ET** earlier this month that electricity demand was expected to decline as the pressure on cooling appliances and irrigation reduced. However, states such as Gujarat and Tamil Nadu continue to see high peak demand. In Gujarat, the peak demand on October 24 was around 28.3 GW, which is almost the same as in much of June. "This could be because of the weather-related demand and some industrial demand moving to the grid," an industry official said.

September had recorded an increase of around 11% in electricity consumption. The sustained demand had also kept electricity prices elevated in the short-term market. Prices in the day-ahead market of the Indian Energy Exchange were hovering above ₹7 per unit during the first half of October. Coal stocks at domestic coal-based power plants stood at 17.3 million tonnes as of October 24, compared with 17.9 million tonnes on October 15 and 18.5 million tonnes at the b ginning of the month.

India Must Bolster Tech, Economic Resilience: Grandy

Deepshikha Sikarwar

New Delhi: India must accelerate the development of domestic technology capabilities, strengthen economic resilience and build safeguards against dependence on foreign artificial intelligence (AI) systems as geopolitical tensions reshape government priorities worldwide, according to Dean Grandy, KPMG's global head for government and public sector.

"India needs the ability to create its own solutions to address national problems. It needs the economic capacity to invest in solutions and areas that will deliver outcomes in its best interests," Grandy told **ET**.

He dismissed concerns over the outflow of capital saying the issue was not specific to India.

"This is a global phenomenon driven by many external factors that attract investment and human capital towards different opportunities and operating environments," he said.

Given geopolitical volatility, no country or region can sustain itself entirely without support from allies, he said. Foreign trade arrangements and multilateral agreements are important because they provide a shared platform for understanding, investment and a common vision for the future.

"Collaboration between like-minded governments, including the sharing of experiences, insights and capabilities, as well as funding arrangements, is essential," he said, adding that these partnerships enable India and other countries to co-invest in their futures.

Geopolitical volatility in the last few years has driven fundamental shifts in the way governments need to think about protecting citizens and ensuring societal and economic well-being, he said.

"This represents a shift away from social well-being towards national security considerations. It has broader implications because there is less money available for welfare, healthcare and education," he said. The shift is also reshaping international partnerships, with allied countries collaborating on large defence and security programmes, he said. Governments have begun to ask how they can build domestic capabilities, secure critical infrastructure and retain control over data.

EXUDING CONFIDENCE

India's scale, economic growth and young population give it a strong foundation for sustainable growth

Grandy said India's scale, economic growth, young population and expanding artificial intelligence capabilities give it a strong foundation for sustainable growth.

ON AI

India, he said, must invest in domestic infrastructure, large language models, digital literacy and technical capabilities while maintaining close links with other governments, he said. It must also be able to intervene quickly when problems emerge around AI access, supply or use, he noted.

Grandy said India should develop its own AI regulations rather than wait for a single global framework. He considered this unlikely because of competing national interests.

"Appropriate safeguards must be in place to ensure that the interests of India, its citizens, its business environment and the data flowing through these systems are protected and managed effectively for the future," he said.

He does not see a single global regulatory framework as a possibility with too many competing interests, particularly among countries at the frontier of AI development.

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How to Attract STEM Talent Back

Create roadmap to break research poverty trap

Ashoke Sen's stature in the world of theoretical physics is universally acknowledged. His latest recognition is the Oskar Klein Medal, awarded for his contributions to the field. Sen, who is based in Bengaluru, is an exception to the pattern of prodigious brain drain that feeds research labs worldwide. India does not figure in the top tier of international academic research establishments, despite supplying them with talent. Paradoxically, the country produces a high volume of research that does not translate into scientific breakthroughs. This has been true for most of the post-Independence period because India does not spend enough on research.

A low level of industrialisation and weak linkages between academic institutions and industry pose the biggest hurdles. Labs work in relative isolation from industrial sectors, delaying the commercialisation of research. Supplementary public funding comes with rigid bureaucratic control that encourages migration. The absence of market signals for research encourages inflated, low-intensity output designed more for career progression than discovery. Scientific research in India is an example of market inefficiency being compounded by state intervention. Work is needed to improve market conditions and policy administration before the country can attempt to reverse its brain drain.

The closest example of a successful retention exercise is China's Thousand Talents Plan, which combined state-backed recruitment with enhanced financial incentives and investment in research infra. The Chinese model has yielded mixed results: it did reverse talent flight but has been criticised for facilitating IP theft. Japan offers a different template, with high corporate investment, a focus on applied tech and a lab-based university structure. Other policy and market models can be found in South Korea and Israel, alongside the well-developed structures of the US and the EU. India needs to draw lessons from all to create its own strategy to break out of the research poverty trap.

Hermès, Try a Scarf Around Just China

Hermès has a problem. Weakening demand in favourite market China has largely led to a downturn in revenue growth. Greater China and the wider Asia-Pacific region account for 40-42% of Hermès' total global revenue. This should make the French luxury brand revisit its marketing strategy. Luxury brands such as Hermès, Chanel, LVMH, Prada need to stick to their USP. What sets luxury brands apart is not just design and quality — 'product' — but the promise of an experience: brand equity riding on qualitative reputation.

Hermes' Birkin bag is popular among 1%-ers. That's the whole point. Europe®, itself now fire-ringed from the turmoil being witnessed, still commands aesthetic-commercial influence and heft for new developed economies like China. So, it makes adequate sense for Hermès to create a 'China-only' line — selling its 'Europeanness' to customers who can afford it.

China's HENRYs — High Earners, Not Rich Yet — are no longer treating that $12,000 Birken bag as a monumental buy. They have been buying high-end local brands that can give the entry-level Birken a run for its money. But it now needs a nudge. European luxury brands are about offering experience to the (affording) world, signalling status that comes with 'beautiful things'. Rather than the affluent mass-market, European luxury brands like Hermès need to focus on 1%-ers, laying out bespoke products that sets China's very own 1%-ers apart by having a 'China-only' line. This doesn't mean dilution. On the contrary, it means encouraging a traditionally strong market towards a 'European' product. What holds true for China, holds for other regions: high-end products/brands — whether a Hermès scarf or a bottle of Chardonnay — can be 'tailor-sold' in certain strategic markets.

JUST IN JEST

No, Vivek Ramaswamy's ethnicity isn't enough for us to like him

Be Picky About Your Desi-Abroad Pride

National pride is a splendid thing — even when it's really disguised ethnic pride that's been made politically acceptable. Indians possess a remarkable talent for discovering Indian greatness abroad. An American wins a Spelling Bee, and civilisation's debt to Sanskrit is established. A British PM has Indian ancestry, and the empire apparently strikes back.

Consider Vivek Ramaswamy, Republican candidate for Ohio governor. His latest contribution to American democracy is an advertisement featuring the estranged mother of his Democratic opponent, Amy Acton, calling her daughter a liar and questioning her mental health. The awkward detail omitted is why mother and daughter became estranged: Acton suffered childhood abuse, and her stepfather was charged with raping her when she was 12.

Even Republicans have recoiled. Ramaswamy, displaying the sensitivity of a bulldozer, plans to spend $4m promoting the ad. Trump, of course, approves. So, is Ramaswamy's ancestry enough for us to junk toxic behaviour and celebrate him? Certainly not. The right thing to do is be a selective Brown supremacist. Celebrate your x degrees of separation from, say, Ashoke Sen, the latest recipient of one of physics' most prestigious prizes. But ignore, say, yet another Indian shoplifter caught at a Brit supermarket. Diaspora-pride is natural. But it needn't be stupid.

GLOBESPOTTING For a better global order, India needs to play a bigger game, alongside US

STRATEGIC HANGING OUT

Indrani Bagchi

Go on, try and team up

The only sign the India-US relationship retains vestiges of a strategic partnership was when Marco Rubio paid tribute at the 26/11 memorial at Mumbai's Taj Mahal Palace. The official US reaffirmation of India's position on post-9/11, post-26/11 cross-border terrorism could be the one bright spot in an otherwise gloomy relationship at a time when Donald Trump's lovefest with Asim Munir is obvious.

India needs to factor 3 developments into its foreign policy:

❶ Strategic dhandha For a quarter of a century, the US assumed a 'strategic, long-term' view of India. That period is decisively over. India is now smack in the middle of the age of pragmatic deal-making, or 'dhandha' as strategy. That is fine, if Indians realise the field is flexible, with spin, seam and yorkers all being bowled in the same over. Field placement is, therefore, more important than ever, since India cannot afford not to engage with this new phase of the US.

Rubio's meeting with the Ambanis was more animated than his meetings with (Indian and UAE) foreign ministers. The former was about buying Venezuelan oil and a refinery in Texas. The latter ticked boxes, including I2U2 and IMEC, both currently hostage to the Iran war.

Rubio met Mukesh Ambani, Gautam Adani and N Chandrasekaran (almost 15 Indian corporate bosses had reportedly sought a meeting). It says one important thing: despite turbulence, both countries continue to find reasons to make money together. Energy, infrastructure, defence and technology are touchpoints of the India-US corridor, a good reason for Rubio to have spent time in India twice in 4 months.

India was saved from Russia tariffs for two reasons: someone in the White House decided that Indian oil refineries are a force for good in the world, and that an India trade deal might be a good idea. Leverage is everything. The trade deal will be 'done' when two things are reconciled — certainty on India tariffs and a roadmap to reduce the US trade deficit.

Meanwhile, India is due to sign trade deals with Canada and the EU in December. So, it can afford to wait for a favourable landing point with the US. Modi will be in Canada, US, and EU in December — 2 out of 3 trade deals would be an acceptable record. It's a good way to deal with the US, and India is proving to be a quick learner.

❷ Rethink diaspora policy For future stability of its US relationship, India needs to rethink its diaspora policy, beyond the previous pomp. Whether it's Trump-Vance Republicans, or Socialist Democrats, MAGA is now baked into the very notion of the US. It threads through an anti-immigrant sentiment, which has a strong race component and is particularly targeted against Indians. It also has a 'success' component that will turn on Indians in a heartbeat. Indians are the most successful, least troublesome, but most in-your-face. For the average American, they got rich by taking American jobs.

Rubio's meeting with the Ambanis was more animated than his meetings with (Indian and UAE) foreign ministers

India needs to differentiate between the MAGA sentiment that targets India, and the one that targets Indian Americans. The latter are American citizens and have political recourse in their adopted country. Let it not become New Delhi's headache. It might put a spanner into Modi's diaspora outreach. But, hey, his first responsibility is to Indian citizens.

India should act on visa policies that target Indian citizens unfairly, and ensure they face a level playing field in whichever country they choose to work in. Trump's H-1B visa restrictions are not actually unfair. Neither is his campaign against illegal immigration.

❸ No U-turn The upcoming US midterm elections and anticipated GOP reverses are unlikely to change much in Trump's foreign policy. Instead, they may free him to take a maximalist approach on Iran, freed from domestic political considerations.

Certainly, Tehran expects it. Given the speed at which US personnel are emptying out of the Gulf, another bruising round in the coming days is expected. It won't break Tehran, or its military leaders. But whether Iran destroys submarine cables or energy infrastructure in the region, the consequences will be catastrophic.

Modi has clearly cautioned Netanyahu against adventurism. China and Russia are also hoping to put the brakes on Iran, as evidenced by Sergey Lavrov and Wang Yi's recent meetings with the Iranians. It's important for India to play a role now. Trump doesn't have the smarts to get out of the war. Iran is bent on vengeance, and Israel is too trigger-happy for its own good.

Meanwhile, Yalta 2.0 is coming — as Trump, Xi and Putin potentially head for a trilateral meeting in Shenzhen in November, a meeting that Putin and Xi will take advantage of while Trump will spew rhetoric. Don't expect a resolution to either the Russia-Ukraine or US-Iran war. But it will be a powerful message to the world.

India needs to differentiate between the MAGA sentiment that targets India, and the one that targets Indian Americans

The Quad summit in Manila will precede the Shenzhen trilateral. With Australia and Japan, India needs to be a more proactive player in Quad to give Trump a plan, something more than bombast, to take to Shenzhen. The future global order cannot remain to the advantage of Russia or China. For a more favourable order, India needs to play a bigger game, with the US.

India is the biggest power in this region. It has huge equities. It's time it got off the sidelines. The war should not be allowed to continue.

The writer is CEO, Ananta Centre

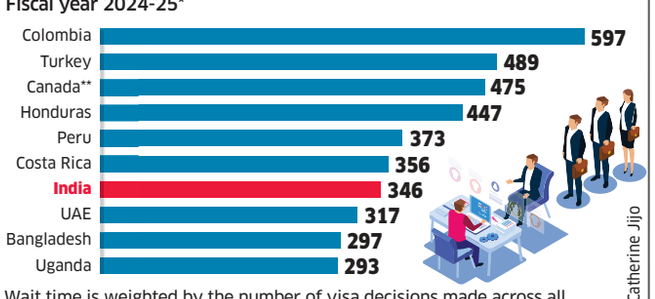
ChatGPT SHAIRI OF THE DAY

Young Jared, Trump's damaad, Kushner,
Was accused of being a Gulf-money gusher;
When the Dutch hacked his phone,
He cried, 'Leave me alone!
I'm a peacemaker, not a bribe-pushner!'
• • •

The Longest US Visa Interview Waits

Forget about getting a US visa on time; even landing an interview is a tough nut to crack. A recent US government study found that the next visa interview slot was 201 days away on average in FY25, nearly eight times what it was in FY19. Colombian visa-seekers have it the worst (20 months), while India ranks seventh with an average wait of nearly a year.

Average Wait Time (in days) for a US Visitor Visa Interview
Fiscal year 2024-25*



Wait time is weighted by the number of visa decisions made across all embassies/consulates in a country. *US fiscal year: Oct-Sept. **Canadians don't need visas for US entry; this is for third-country citizens.
Source: U.S. Government Accountability Office

By Anna Catherine Jijo

MEME'S THE WORD

Don't Bank on RBI Alone

Ajay Tyagi

RBI tightly regulates commercial banks and mandates their listing to improve transparency. But while it prioritises depositors' interests over those of investors, what about safeguarding the latter's interests?

The economy's financial stability depends on the smooth functioning of banks, which RBI is tasked with ensuring. It has nominee directors on the boards of PSBs and, often, on other banks' boards. Some argue that, as the lender of last resort, RBI must be closely involved in banks' operations. It also relies on banks for its commercial activities and market operations. In this backdrop, it is difficult to perceive that RBI operates at arm's length from the entities it regulates. This could be problematic. Among other concerns, close involvement may create a perception that the regulator is lenient in granting forbearance to banks.

Listed banks face less rigorous disclosure requirements than other entities listed on stock exchanges. RBI frequently issues banks directions and often keeps these, along with its inspection findings, confidential. Only RBI officials and the banks concerned know the details. Some directions and deficiencies identified during inspections may have financial implications.

These concerns manifest themselves in 3 areas: inadequate disclosure, lack of transparency in bank resolution and weak governance of PSBs.

❶ Not enough public disclosure Despite listing requirements, banks often fail to disclose information to the market promptly. When problems eventually come to light, markets react sharply, catching investors off guard.

Banks argue that sensitivities prevent timely disclosure and that they need RBI's prior permission to share such information. The extent to which they can withhold information warrants scrutiny by the market regulator in consultation with RBI.

❷ Under cover RBI's process for restructuring, reconstructing or amalgamating banks lacks transparency. Under Banking Regulation Act, 1949, RBI can unilaterally frame a scheme to reconstruct a bank or compulsorily amalgamate it with another banking entity if it finds the bank critically mismanaged or financially insolvent. Such action does not require the prior consent of the bank's shareholders, members or creditors.

A case in point is Yes Bank's 2020 bailout, under which ₹8,415 cr of AT1 bonds held by investors were permanently written down, wiping out their investments. Bondholders challenged the move and won in the Bombay High Court. RBI, GoI and Yes Bank appealed against the ruling, but Supreme Court dismissed their appeals, upholding the bondholders' case.

More importantly, should a regulator also act as the resolution authority for entities it regulates? Concerned that an entity's failure might reflect poorly on its supervisory record, the regulator may give a distressed entity too much leeway to recover. Bank insolvency resolution requires a specialised statutory authority operating under a transparent, well-defined procedure. Notably, Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016 does not cover financial firms, including banks.

GoI introduced a bill in 2017 to set up a resolution corporation to handle financial firm failures. But it was withdrawn in 2018 following concerns over some contentious provisions. It must redraft the legislation and introduce it in Parliament soon.

Lost in the system

❸ PSB governance Public sector banks (PSBs) are regulated by both RBI and GoI, an arrangement that the apex bank has previously questioned. Governance of PSBs leaves much to be desired. For instance, GoI appoints all directors to PSB boards, both executive and independent. It also determines staff salaries and incentive schemes, including those for EDs and key managerial personnel, across all PSBs, with broadly similar structures. Such an arrangement would be unthinkable in a private sector commercial entity.

In private sector banks, Companies Act and Sebi regulations entrust this responsibility to the Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC), a key board committee. What, then, is the role of NRCs in PSBs?

Listed PSBs routinely seek exemptions from Sebi's Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements (LODR), often citing government ownership as grounds for differential treatment. These include exemptions from minimum public shareholding requirements and the mandated number of independent directors on their boards.

These requirements are the bedrock of listing regulations. Diluting them compromises investor interests, distorts the playing field between public and private sector entities, and undermines market discipline.

Then there are PSBs that are not incorporated as companies under Companies Act but are established under specific statutes. The Acts governing these banks were enacted decades ago, and many of their provisions are not in line with LODR requirements, which Sebi has amended from time to time to reflect market developments.

These Acts should be repealed, and the banks incorporated under Companies Act, bringing them under the same regulatory requirements as other listed entities.

The writer is former chairman, SEBI

MELODY FOR MONDAY

I Wanna Be Adored The Stone Roses

Few songs make longing sound quite as majestic as The Stone Roses' 'I Wanna Be Adored', the opening track of their magnificent 1989 debut album. It begins almost imperceptibly with a low, subterranean rumble before the late Gary 'Mani' Mounfield's hypnotic bassline emerges.

John Squire's shimmering guitar gathers momentum, and Alan 'Reni' Wren's drums give the music its irresistible, unhurried propulsion. Ian Brown's voice, cool and seemingly indifferent, floats above this gathering magnificence, expressing a desire that is anything but indifferent.

Brown's repeated insistence that he needs no worldly transaction, merely adoration, can sound like narcissism. It isn't. Read it as, say, a shyamasangeet addressed to Kali, and the resemblance becomes deliciously persuasive.

Don't get fooled by the English gendered pronoun in, 'I don't have to/ sell my soul/ He's already in me.' While the song naturally eludes to 'oneself', it can easily jump to the 'divine her,' if you're inclined to 'her-ness'.

Rejection of worldly exchange, obsessive repetition, yearning for unconditional recognition: these are as much bhakti as the late-80s-early 90s 'Madchester' scene.

THE SPEAKING TREE

Neither Here Nor There

NARAYANI GANESH

Memorials, remembrances, cenotaphs, headstones, death day tributes and rituals, mausoleums, crypts, columbariums, sarcophagus, pyramids, memorial trees and gardens, dedicated benches — all of these physical reminders are intended to keep the one who has passed on, alive in our memories.

On the contrary, in Saudi Arabia where the Wahabi Sunni Islamic tradition is followed, in the case of even monarchs and other exalted figures, when they are no more, their remains are interred in unmarked graves alongside ordinary persons. You cannot recognise which one is whose grave. Death creates a kind of democratic equity that may not have been the case when they were alive.

Why do we need physical reminders of the one who is no longer with us in body? Would we not remember them, otherwise?

Vietnamese Zen master Thich Nhat Hanh, whose birth centenary is being celebrated this year as the Year of Mindfulness, said, "I have a disciple in Vietnam who wants to build a stupa for my ashes when I die, with a plaque: 'Here lies my beloved teacher.' Instead of wasting temple land, I suggested — if they still insist on a stupa — the plaque could say, 'I am not here.' But in case people don't get it, they could add, 'I am not out there either.' If still people don't understand, then you can write, 'I may be found in your way of breathing and walking.'" So, it is better to remember the deceased's teachings, good deeds and kindness, and try to emulate those rather than ritualise and glorify bones and ashes.

Chat Room

Value Over Novelty Sells

Apropos the Edit, 'Smartphones Need Some New Smart Sell' (Oct 24). The smartphone industry is facing a reality check as consumers increasingly prioritise durability, repairability and real utility over gimmicks and frequent upgrades. While expanding domestic assembly and exports offer near-term gains, sustained growth will depend on moving up the value chain through component manufacturing, R&D and intellectual property creation. In the long run, market leaders will be those that deliver lasting value and meaningful innovation rather than incremental novelty.
Amarjeet Kumar, Hazaribagh (Jharkhand)

A Profitable Home Reset

Apropos 'Diwali Decluttering Creates More Room for Organisers' Business' by Nupur Amarnath (Oct 25). The article highlights a notable shift in urban Indian households. As families embrace festive cleaning, demand for professional decluttering services has surged, creating new business opportunities. The trend reflects rising affluence and the willingness of time-strapped professionals to outsource household tasks. It also shows how service providers are turning a traditional pre-Diwali ritual into a thriving commercial enterprise.

Sanjay Chopra, Mohali (Punjab)

Do Your Bit for Cleaner Air

Apropos the Edit, 'For Delhi's Air, Nip Pollutants in the Bud' (Oct 23). While every Delhiite suffers from air pollution, few are willing to make the changes needed to reduce it. The continued use of loud and polluting firecrackers during Diwali worsens the city's air and noise pollution. Delhi can hope for cleaner air only when its residents do their part and adopt more responsible practices.
Bhagyendra Patel, Delhi

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SMART INVESTING

AI Narrative Needs to Change For India: Citibank India CEO

LOOK TO TAP ₹2,768 CR

IPO Season's in Full Swing, 9 More Cos to Hit the Street

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Five mainboard and four SME initial public offerings (IPOs) will open for subscription next week, collectively seeking to raise ₹2,768 crore.

EAAA India Alternatives will be the largest mainboard offering, aiming to raise ₹1,200 crore, followed by SFC Environmental Technologies at ₹667.53 crore and MK Sons Fine Jewels at ₹275.40 crore. BLS Polymers and Bombay Coated & Special Steels will seek to raise ₹255 crore and ₹183.06 crore, respectively.

In the SME segment, Wiscon Industries, Ajwa Projects, Carver Roboweld and Antala Industries will open their IPOs next week. Core4 Engineers, whose IPO opened last week, will close for subscription on October 27.

Two mainboard companies are also scheduled to list on October 28. These include Jio Platforms, which raised more than ₹30,000 crore through its IPO last week, and Paras Healthcare, which raised around ₹1,450 crore.

RELATIVE VALUE Indian equities trade at 18.5 times forward earnings versus 8.7 times for EMs

Valuations Hit 6-Year Lows but More Expensive than EM Peers

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: India's equity valuations are at their lowest levels in six years following the recent market decline sparked by a slew of factors, including foreign selling, a weaker rupee, higher crude prices and rising US bond yields. But that may not be reason enough for overseas investors to reverse their pessimistic view, as stocks here, despite coming off their highs, remain more expensive than their emerging market (EM) peers.

The dollar-denominated MSCI India Index trades at around 18.5 times its 12-month forward price-to-earnings (P/E) ratio, the lowest level since May 2020. It hit a record high of 24.54 times in September 2024, when the Sensex and Nifty reached their all-time highs.

The valuation measure is down from 22.5 times at the start of the year and below its 10-year average of 19.7 times, but investors do not appear to be in a hurry to pile into battered Indian equities.

"The Nifty forward PE looks cheap only if you believe the forward EPS," said Vivek Iyer, partner and CIO at Rational Equity Asset Management. "With crude where it is, we think consensus estimates still have cuts ahead, so the true multiple is higher than the headline."

In dollar terms, the Sensex and Nifty are down 18%-19% so far in 2026, while MSCI India has fallen 15.4%. Other than MSCI China, which has dropped 20%, most other markets are up.

Iyer said the recent equity decline is more of a "large-cap de-rating" as mid- and small-cap stocks are still trading at a 50%-70% premium to their historical medians. "The broader market has not reset at all. The reset is incomplete," he said.

Foreign investors tend to compare Indian equities with their regional peers. The MSCI Emerging Markets Index trades at 8.7 times forward earnings, down from 13.3 times at the beginning of the year and below its 10-year average of 12.05 times. India's valuation is roughly double that of EMs.

Among other major markets, MSCI US, the most expensive, trades at around 18.8 times one-year forward earnings against its 10-year average of 19.2 times and has gained 12% in dollar terms so far this year. Taiwan and Japan trade at 16.8 times and 15.4 times forward earnings, respectively, versus 10-year averages of 15 times each, with the two markets gaining 57% and 17% this year. China trades at 9.2 times forward earnings versus its 10-year average of 11.5 times.

The argument in favour of India is that Indian equities have always traded at a premium to their peers because of the country's relatively stable corporate earnings outlook and broad-based market.

Continued on ▸▸ Smart Investing

How India Stacks Up

Index Name	1 Year Forwad PE	5 Year Average	10 Year Average	YTD % (in Dollar Terms)
MSCI USA	18.8	20.2	19.2	11.8
MSCI India	18.5	21.3	19.7	-15.4
MSCI World	17.6	18.0	17.5	10.5
MSCI Taiwan	16.8	15.9	15.1	57.0
MSCI Japan	15.4	15.2	15.0	16.9
MSCI Thailand	14.7	16.4	16.1	13.8
MSCI Global	12.3	11.7	12.8	7.7
MSCI China	9.2	10.6	11.5	-20.2
MSCI EM	8.7	11.9	12.0	12.2
MSCI Korea	3.7	9.6	9.8	58.0
BSE Sensex	16.7	19.9	19.0	-18.7
Nifty 50	16.7	19.5	18.6	-18.1

Source: Bloomberg

BLACKROCK INSTITUTE SEES SOME OPPORTUNITIES

'Foreign Investors Looking for Bit More Earnings Comfort'

Top exec Ben Powell awaits clarity on oil and stable global yields

Himadri Buch

Mumbai: BlackRock Investment Institute is not yet ready to turn bullish on Indian equities in the near term despite valuations becoming more attractive, said Ben Powell, the firm's chief investment strategist for the Middle East and APAC. BlackRock is awaiting greater clarity on corporate earnings, crude oil prices, global bond yields and foreign fund flows before turning more positive on Indian equities.

"We are poised to turn a little bit more tactically constructive," said Abu Dhabi-based Powell in an interview over a video call. "The valuation is more interesting, but we want to see a bit more evidence," he said. BlackRock Investment Institute has allocated a higher share to Indian equities than their weight in global benchmarks. However, the firm remains more neutral in the near term as geopolitical risks, elevated energy prices and global yields could cloud the outlook.

In India, he sees opportunities in energy, defence and manufacturing as countries respond to geopolitical uncertainty. India's benchmark indices have underperformed most large peers in 2026. The Sensex is down 14.16%, while the Nifty is down 13.5%.

When asked when foreign investors could return to India, Powell said they were looking for greater stability and upward momentum in corporate earnings before increasing their exposure to Indian equities. "We just need to see a little bit more comfort on the earnings directly before we can see those flows over time," he said.

Foreign investors have remained net sellers since July 2025. In 2026, they have sold Indian equities worth ₹4.55 lakh crore. According to BlackRock Investment Institute, between 2016 and 2025, about $5 of every $100 in assets acquired by households went into shares, investment funds and debt securities. Powell projects this to rise to $20 between 2026 and 2035.

CRUDE PRICE IMPACT

Higher crude oil prices have posed a challenge for India as a major energy importer, but the economy has shown resilience, according to Powell. He believes that the growth outlook has remained good, although elevated energy costs would gradually feed into inflation across sectors.

Brent crude oil prices have surged over 9% in the past month, driven by escalating geopolitical tensions and supply disruption fears in the Middle East. The global benchmark is trading near $116.72 per barrel.

US FED, BOND YIELDS & AI

Volatility in South Korean and Taiwanese markets has raised questions about whether the AI investment boom has peaked. Powell said demand, earnings and capital expenditure in the sector remained strong, with money continuing to flow into AI infrastructure.

While the AI investment boom continues to attract funding, higher capital costs will widen the gap between companies that generate strong returns and those that struggle, according to Powell.

Eight of Top-10 Cos Lose ₹1.55 Lcr Mcap

New Delhi: The combined market valuation of eight of the top 10 most valuable firms fell by ₹1.55 lakh crore last week, with HDFC Bank and Bajaj Finance making for most of the losses. In a holiday-truncated week, the 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 1,605.44 points, or 2.15%, while the 50-share NSE Nifty slumped 546.15 points, or 2.36%. Tracking the weak trend in equities, the total market capitalisation of BSE-listed firms fell by ₹20,78,774.28 crore over 4 sessions to ₹4,51,83,393.14 crore from ₹4,72,62,167.42 crore recorded on October 16. The market valuation of HDFC Bank tumbled ₹55,506.95 crore to ₹10,67,121.12 crore. **PTI**

FROM CAUTIOUS TO AGGRESSIVE IN TWO YEARS

Did Balanced Advantage Funds Buy the Dip?

Abhinav Kaul

Balanced advantage funds (BAFs) or dynamic asset allocation funds (DAAFs) promise to manage equity-debt allocation automatically — buying dips, trimming peaks. The 2024–2026 market cycle, with a 20%-plus correction in Nifty 500 index followed by some recovery, put that promise to a real test: did funds buy the dip, or just shield themselves from losses?

For More Pick Up Today's The Economic Times wealth

Despite differences between individual funds, the direction of travel over the past two years has been consistent. BAFs, as a group, became meaningfully more aggressive. According to data available with PrimeInvestor and fund house factsheets, the average net equity allocation of 34 BAFs/DAAFs with a track record of at least two years rose from 52.65% in September 2024 to 64.98% in August 2026 — a rise of 12.33 percentage points at the category level. Further, 30 of these 34 schemes increased their net equity exposure over this period.

The funds that moved the most did so decisively. LIC MF BAF recorded the largest increase, rising by 30.72 percentage points. Union BAF was not far behind, at 29.89 percentage points. Biggest two funds in the category by assets — HDFC BAF and ICICI Prudential BAF — increased net allocations by 24.06 percentage points and 26.62 percentage points, respectively, while Baroda BNP Paribas BAF's net equity holding rose by 23.78 percentage points.

Gross equity is a BAF's total equity holding, including positions hedged through derivatives, contracts that offset market risk. Remove that hedged portion and you get net equity: the share of portfolio exposed to market movements. In a BAF, net equity is the number that matters. A rising net equity signals the fund is taking on market risk — betting on a recovery.

Continued on ▸▸ Smart Investing

Industries and Mines Department Government of Gujarat

Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation

GUJARAT INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION
(A Government of Gujarat Undertaking)
Block No. 3, 4 & 5, Udyog Bhavan, Sector-11, Gandhinagar - 382011
Phone: +91-79-23250632, 34 to 37 | Website: www.gidc.gujarat.gov.in

BE A PART OF GUJARAT'S
INDUSTRIAL GROWTH STORY

Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation (GIDC) invites applications for allotment of industrial plots exclusively for ceramic industries in the following estate from **26-10-2026.**

Regional Office	District	Estate	Scheme Name
Rajkot	Morbi	Jambudiya Paneli	General (Industrial – Non Chemical) Only for Ceramic Industries

Important Instructions

- Apply through the GIDC website: **https://egov.gidcgujarat.org/gidc/frmgeneralterms.aspx**
- GIDC has not authorised any third party or agency for plot allotment. Applicants may contact GIDC offices. Contact details are available on **https://gidc.gujarat.gov.in//Pages/Contents/Contactus**
- For portal-related queries, contact **9879110007, 9879110463, 9879110478 or 9879110482** during office working hours.

Jambudiya Paneli Ceramic Park by GIDC

Industries and Mines Department Government of Gujarat

Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation

GUJARAT'S
MEDICAL DEVICE PARK
at Nagalpar, Rajkot
Opens for Industrial Plot Allotment

GIDC is Developing a Dedicated Park Spreading Across **336 Acres** for **Medical Devices Manufacturing,** with Common Infrastructure Facilities built around Medical Devices Manufacturing.

Online applications will be accepted from:
26th October 2026
For Manufacturers of Medical Devices, Equipment and Allied Components.

Important Points

- For application and other details, visit the link **https://egov.gidcgujarat.org/gidc/frmgeneralterms.aspx**
- Contact details are available on **https://gidc.gujarat.gov.in//Pages/Contents/Contactus**
- For portal-related queries, contact **9879110007, 9879110463, 9879110478** or **9879110482** during office working hours.

GIDC Medical Device Park, Nagalpar, Rajkot, Gujarat

AI Narrative Needs to Change For India

ET Q&A

Three years after exiting the consumer business, Citibank India has strengthened its institutional-banking franchise. Its client-asset book crossed ₹1 lakh crore. In an interview with **Sangita Mehta and Joel Rebello**, CEO **K Balasubramanian** said he remains optimistic on India's IPO revenue stream, foreign investors continue to favour markets offering "disproportionate returns" and stronger AI-linked opportunities. Edited excerpts:

Foreign investors have pulled money out of India. What will bring them back?
Foreign investors will come in if they get a disproportionate return compared with other markets. Today, unfortunately, Indian returns have not been very disproportionate. They have options to invest in multiple markets and will compare your P/E with another country's P/E. Earlier this year, Taiwan and Korea were among the biggest draws.

The US market continues to grow very strongly. Despite everything you hear in terms of inflation and unemployment, core growth across sectors continues to be quite decent. AI is a very big play in the US. Unfortunately, India doesn't have too much to show on AI. Combining these factors, I think no new foreign capital is coming in. That will change only if the global AI story changes. India is often seen as a counter-trade to the AI story.

What can India do to attract more durable foreign investment?
Long-term capital-gains tax is a big factor on the equity side. On direct investment, the trade agreements are going to be a big positive. Trade agreements create potentially important UK-India and EU-India corridors. We have been doing a lot of work identifying companies that could benefit and engage with clients. For Citi, that opportunity can flow through services and markets and potentially through investment-banking transactions as multinational companies raise capital in India. There are at least half a dozen live discussions with multinationals looking at potential capital raising in India.

There are concerns about IPO pricing and retail investor appetite. Are valuations becoming an impediment?
For the right company, pricing is not an issue. The market has corrected from the levels where the Nifty was trading around 24-25 times forward earnings to around 20-21 times. If Indian companies can deliver mid-to-high-teens growth, those valuations can be justified.

Retail investors may not necessarily be coming directly into every IPO, but they are participating indirectly through mutual funds. Domestic institutional capital has therefore become a significant part of the IPO market.

How does the IPO pipeline look from here?
There are three or four transactions of around the billion-dollar range that we are factoring in between now and the end of the year, and Citi is involved in two or three of them. Going into next year, the pipeline continues to build. More than a dozen companies have filed DRHPs and are at different stages of preparation. A lot will depend on where markets are, but I remain optimistic.

How did Citibank India perform after exiting the consumer loan business?
Our strategy has been to focus on businesses where we are either among the top three or believe we can get there within a reasonable period. After exiting the consumer business, we reinvested capital and management bandwidth into the core institutional banking franchise. Between March 2023 and March 2026, our institutional revenues, excluding consumer, rose 76% (a CAGR of 21%). Net income rose 56% (about 16% CAGR). Loans grew 78%, while deposits grew 48% over this period. In FY 2026 our net profit rose 17.3% to ₹7,261 crore and total income was up 4.5% to ₹23,176 crore.

How much did Citi raise through the FCNR(B) opportunity?
We couldn't raise FCNR(B) on our books because of the non-compete with Axis Bank until March 2027. We partnered with Axis Bank and raised about $1.5 billion. Including about $2 billion of our own offshore borrowing and roughly $1 billion of ECBs raised for clients, Citi's involvement was in the zip code of $5 billion.

What opportunities open up once the Axis Bank non-compete ends?
Potentially, we can do everything we could earlier. It is still early days, but if there is another FCNR opportunity, the answer is definitely yes. Wealth is another area we could look at. We already have an offshore wealth business; the question is how we originate onshore for offshore.

How has growth been after exiting the retail segment? What is the outlook on the loan book?
Our balance sheet size has grown 16.3% YoY to ₹3.14 lakh crore. In the second quarter, Citi India's institutional client asset portfolio crossed ₹1 lakh crore. This is significant because even when we had the consumer business, we did not have rupee client-asset book of this scale. We expect around 20% year-on-year growth. But we don't want to grow for the sake of growth. We can raise deposits and grow faster, but not if deposits become too expensive. We need to find the right returns while maintaining robust underwriting.

How has Citi India's investment banking performed?
It has been pretty good. We have been involved in several big-ticket advisory transactions, and M&A continues to be material for us. On ECM, we have helped companies raise about $16 billion capital.

Deal sizes are also becoming quite material, with transactions ranging from $750 million to $1 billion. There is also significant block activity as financial sponsors and investors monetise portions of their holdings. Citi has 28% market share in M&A league table as per Dealogic.

How important is GIFT City to Citi's expansion?
It is a big focus area. Our GIFT City assets have grown from about $300-400 million in March 2026 to around $2.5 billion now. We are looking at optimising our balance sheet and expanding our product offering as more clients come into GIFT City. Since it is a standalone branch of Citi New York, the assets do not consolidate into Citibank India's balance sheet.

FOR FULL INTERVIEW, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Policy Doctor: Health Insurance Guide

PUNEET OBEROI
FOUNDER, FINWISE SERVICES

I purchased a health insurance policy with a sum insured of ₹10 lakh, but my experience during my cashless claim processing has raised concerns about the actual coverage available. During my hospital admission for an umbilical hernia procedure at a well-known hospital in Bengaluru, the hospital bill amounted to ₹3.27 lakh, but the insurance company approved only ₹75,000, citing a sub-limit for the procedure. A subsequent claim, related to treatment for abdominal pain, was denied on the grounds of exhaustion of the sub-limit. This, despite the fact that my treating surgeon confirmed the second admission was unrelated to the earlier procedure. What recourse do I have now? — *SN Rajesh, Bengaluru*

RESPONSE:
Your experience shows why the fine print in insurance contracts matters. Always study the policy wordings before buying, and during the free-look period. Sub-limits are contractual. If the hernia cap was stated in your policy, the ₹75,000 payout will be difficult to contest. The second claim, however, stands apart. If the admission was unrelated to the earlier procedure, as your surgeon confirms, the hernia sub-limit should not apply. You should look to escalate the grievance. Complain to the insurer's grievance cell with the surgeon's certificate. If there is no reply within 30 days, or if it is unsatisfactory, approach the Insurance Ombudsman. Next, you must review your health cover. Consider porting to a policy without disease-wise sublimits, while declaring your full medical history, including the hernia procedure.

Have a health insurance query? Write to us at etwealth@timesofindia.com

UP 78 BASIS POINTS IN THE PAST 4 MONTHS

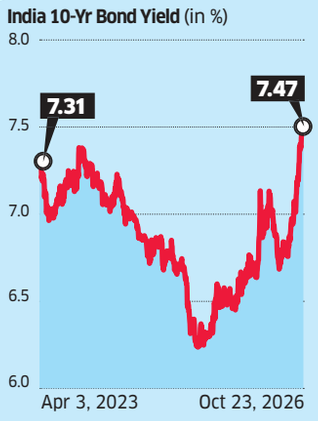
G-Sec Yields at 3-Year Peak, could Climb to 7.75% by December

Scaling New Heights

10 year yield expectations

InCred Global Asset Management	7.50% to 7.60%, unless brent prices retreat
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	as high as 7.75% if similar conditions persist
DBS Bank	7.65%-7.70%, base case is of high oil prices
PNB Gilts	7.60% if brent prices rise further
CSB Bank	broad range of 7.45% to 7.65%
South Indian Bank	7.61% a key level, it was the high during previous hike cycle

India 10-Yr Bond Yield (in %)



Rozebud Gonsalves

Mumbai: India's benchmark 10-year government bond yield is headed toward levels last seen during the 2022-23 tightening cycle, with traders warning that elevated crude oil prices, persistent debt supply, tight banking-system liquidity and expectations of further monetary tightening could push yields to 7.75% by December. The benchmark 10-year yield settled at 7.47% on Friday, its highest level since March 2023.

The yield has surged 78 basis points over the past four months, almost nearing the 7.61% peak touched during the previous rate-hike cycle.

Bankers said the selloff is being driven by a combination of external and domestic factors, with crude oil emerging as the biggest risk for bond investors. Foreign portfolio investors (FPI) have sold ₹20,772 crore from Indian debt so far this fiscal year, NSDL data showed. "The rate differential between India and the US justifies higher yields. At a time when the market is struggling with heavy bond supply, liquidity is getting drained and crude oil prices are moving higher, I expect the 10-year yield to touch 7.75% by December," said Rajeev Pawar, head of treasury, Ujjivan Small Finance Bank.

Brent crude futures rose to $116.72 a barrel, their highest level since April, according to Reuters data. The sharp rise has raised concerns over inflation and the current account deficit as India imports bulk of its crude oil requirements.

Treasury dealers said the market's earlier assumption that disruptions from the US-Iran conflict would be temporary has now given way to fears that elevated oil prices could persist through year-end, keeping inflation risks alive and delaying any meaningful decline in bond yields.

"There seems to be little respite for bond yields unless crude prices cool. This is not just a local story. It is an oil and treasury shock spreading across emerging markets," said Tanuj Khosla, MD at InCred Global Asset Management.

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty Outlook Bearish, But Near-Term Recovery In Sight

The Nifty fell over 2% during the week amid sustained selling pressure. Analysts see support at 22,150–22,350 and resistance at 22,800-23,200. While bearish signals dominate the broader outlook, a close above a key technical indicator suggests scope for a near-term recovery.

TANMAY SHAH
HEAD OF TECHNICAL RESEARCH, **SIHL**

The Nifty is consolidating around its 200-week moving average, with 22,150 emerging as crucial support. A close above the daily supertrend indicator (5,1,5) at 22,560 signals improving near-term momentum and scope for recovery.

Nifty Strategy:
For the November 3, 2026 expiry, buy the 22,600 call at ₹249 and sell the 22,950 call at ₹110. The bull call spread has a net debit of ₹139, a stop-loss at ₹60 on the spread premium and a target of ₹270.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

IGIL: Buy | CMP: ₹381.15 | Target: ₹406 | Stop loss: ₹358.
A strong move following prolonged consolidation, healthy delivery volumes and a firm RSI indicate renewed buying interest.

JSW Cement: Buy | CMP: ₹116.98 | Target: ₹121.70 | Stop loss: ₹113.
A sustained close above the 20-day moving average and an RSI above 50 indicate strengthening momentum.

SUMEET BAGADIA
TECHNICAL ANALYST AND EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, **CHOICE EQUITY BROKING**

Nifty's weekly RSI at 37.34 indicates weak momentum. Support is placed at 22,200–22,350, with resistance at 23,000. The outlook remains bearish below this level.

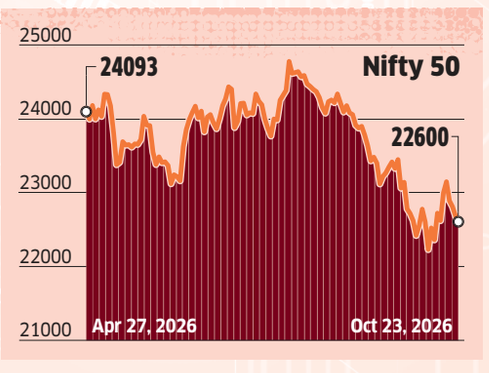
Nifty Strategy:
Sell November futures on rallies towards 22,900, with a stop loss at 23,200 and targets of 22,500 and 22,300. The futures were quoted at 22,679.90.

Bank Nifty Strategy:
Sell November futures on rallies towards 54,800–55,000, with a stop-loss at 55,500 and targets of 54,000 and 53,700. The futures were at 54,562.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

Cipla: Buy | CMP: ₹1,338 | Target: ₹1,450 | Stop loss: ₹1,265. A breakout above the previous week's high and a Hammer pattern indicate recovery potential, with the stock holding above its 200-week EMA.

ONGC: Buy | CMP: ₹227.50 | Target: ₹250 | Stop loss: ₹215. A breakout from sideways consolidation, rising volumes, MACD crossover and trading above the 20-day EMA support the bullish setup.



SUDEEP SHAH
HEAD OF TECHNICAL AND DERIVATIVE RESEARCH, **SBI SECURITIES**

The Nifty's recovery attempt stalled near the 38.2% Fibonacci retracement level around 23,200, resulting in a bearish weekly candle. The index remains below key moving averages, with the daily RSI approaching 40. Support lies at 22,350–22,300; a break below 22,300 could drag the index towards 22,000. Resistance is placed at 22,800–22,850, near the 20-day EMA.

Nifty Strategy:
Avoid aggressive leveraged positions and consider staggered buying in fundamentally strong stocks. Nifty IT remains relatively resilient, while CPSE, PSE, Defence, Consumer Durables, Oil & Gas, Energy, Financial Services, Capital Markets, FMCG, Commodities, Metals, Realty and Chemicals may remain under pressure.

TOP STOCKS FOR THE WEEK

Bharti Hexa: Buy | CMP: ₹1,638 | Target: ₹1,760 | Stop loss: ₹1,575. The stock is consolidating in the ₹1,578–1,679 range, with resistance at ₹1,675–1,680. Accumulation is recommended at ₹1,625–1,645.

IPCA Laboratories: Buy | CMP: ₹1,954 | Target: ₹2,050–2,080. The stock has outperformed the broader market after recovering from ₹1,800. A sustained move above ₹2,000 could pave the way for ₹2,050–2,080.

RBI Builds Sovereign Data Centre to Secure Fin Services

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) newly inaugurated sovereign data centre will strengthen the resilience of critical financial services without reliance on third-party cloud service providers, Governor Sanjay Malhotra said.

A data centre is the heart and nerve centre of any organisation, especially the central bank of a country, Malhotra told a news channel after the inauguration. Information technology is no longer a support function for RBI but a core function because all its applications for the public, consumers and internal use run on it, he said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated RBI's data centre and cybersecurity training institute in Bhubaneswar on Sunday. The facility will house the central bank's mission-critical systems, including the Real Time Gross Settlement, or RTGS, and National Electronic Funds Transfer, or NEFT, systems.

The cybersecurity training institute will build expertise in cybersecurity, artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies, RBI said in a press release.

Malhotra said the data centre would improve the quality and efficiency of services offered to citizens while strengthening the resilience of the broader financial system.

"It is sovereign. We do not depend on third-party cloud service providers; we have our own data centre," he said. One-third of the site has been allocated to the data centre, while two-thirds has been earmarked for the cybersecurity training institute.

Data centre in Bhubaneswar will boost fin services resilience without relying on third-party cloud service providers

The institute will train RBI employees and personnel from banks and other financial institutions in areas such as artificial intelligence, big-data analytics, quantum computing and blockchain. It will undertake research aimed at making financial systems more secure and efficient.

"Cybersecurity is becoming increasingly important, especially in the wake of artificial intelligence," Malhotra said. "It is important that we train in not only our own RBI personnel but also people from banks and other financial system organisations."

The Bhubaneswar location was chosen partly because RBI's three existing data centres are in Maharashtra. Its geographical distance from those centres and location in a different seismic zone will provide greater diversification, while the availability of skilled workers was another factor, he said. RBI's payment systems operate around the clock. Although the Unified Payments Interface is operated by the National Payments Corporation of India, the final settlement of UPI transactions takes place through RBI's data centres and applications, Malhotra said.

Balanced Advantage Funds

▸▸ From ET Markets Page 1

The return data over the period shows a wide spread between the best and worst performers. ICICI Prudential BAF returned -0.37% over one year and 4.07% annualised over two years. Aditya Birla Sun Life BAF returned 1.77% over one year and 4.03% over two years. Parag Parikh DAAF returned 1.54% over one year and 3.57% over two years.

The category average for one year was -3.16%, and 0.15% annualised over two years. For context, the Nifty 500 Total Return Index returned -6.21% over one year and -1.72% annualised over two years. At the other end, Motilal Oswal BAF returned -6.16% over one year and -7.21% annualised over two years. Samco Dynamic Asset Allocation Fund returned -6.08% over one year and -5.05% over two years. The returns for the BAF/DAAF category and Nifty 500 for one and two years are as of 19 October 2026.

As per experts, BAFs need to be assessed over full market cycles to determine whether they deliver on their investment objective. Their performance should be judged by how effectively they balance returns and risk in different market conditions, rather than by their performance during isolated rallies or corrections.

Read the full story in today's edition of ET Wealth.

Insurance Commission: IRDAI Extends Time for Feedback...

Deadline extended to October 31 following stakeholder comments

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) extended the deadline for feedback on its consultation paper on insurance distribution commissions to October 31 from October 25, after receiving more than 650 comments from stakeholders.

The consultation paper was released on September 23 and proposes changes to commission structures and distribution practices to improve efficiency and policyholder value.

"In view of the significant interest and to facilitate wider participation, the last date for submission of comments has been extended till 31st October 2026, providing additional time to stakeholders and members of the public to submit their feedback and suggestions," the regulator said.

The regulator is engaging with different stakeholder groups and has not reached a conclusion on the proposals, IRDAI chairman Ajay Seth had said recently.

The objective is to move towards a more efficient regime without disrupting existing businesses or livelihoods.

Some stakeholders have sought a longer transition period, while others have raised concerns about low-ticket policies, Seth had said. Larger insurers, smaller companies and new entrants have different concerns, as do various categories of insurance distributors.

The regulator has sought comments backed by business and economic reasoning, particularly on how the proposed changes would benefit policyholders. IRDAI said every suggestion would be carefully considered before it decides on the way forward.

Insurance brokers have raised concerns that the proposed changes could hurt distribution businesses, reduce revenues by 60 to 70% and lead to employment losses. Seth has also said the reforms could create new business opportunities within and beyond the insurance sector, depending on how the transition is structured.

The consultation process will be followed by a draft regulation and another round of public consultation, allowing stakeholders to provide further feedback.

Seth had said it was too early to estimate when the draft would be ready, given the need to examine submissions and determine an orderly transition from the existing framework.

THE RISK FACTOR

The regulator received over 650 responses flagging revenue, distribution and employment risks

INDUSTRY SAYS CUTS COULD HAMPER EXPANSION

...NBFCs Seek 5-Year Transition Period to Reduce Selling Fee

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: Finance companies have sought a five-year transition period to reduce insurance commissions and permission to pay premiums directly to insurers on behalf of borrowers.

The industry body of NBFCs has told the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) that the proposed commission caps of 2% for credit life and 5% for credit health insurance would make credit-linked insurance distribution unviable, given distribution costs are about 32% of the premium.

NBFCs have proposed a phased reduction in commissions from the current 45-49% to 25% over five years, warning steep cuts could force lenders to exit the insurance distribution business.

In its October 24 submission to IRDAI, the Finance Industry Development Council (FIDC) said the proposed caps risk undermining the distribution infrastructure needed to expand insurance penetration, particularly in rural and semi-urban areas.

"Just like the manufacturers have been provided with a 5-year glide path for expense of management alignment, NBFCs distributors should also be provided with a similar path on attenuation of commission structures over a 5-year period," said FIDC in a letter to IRDAI adding NBFCs would voluntarily bring down the commission structures from the current high 40s to an acceptable 25% over a period of 5 years.

FIDC said that the proposed commission structure overlooks the customer acquisition, technology, compliance and servicing costs borne by lenders. Its activity-based cost model estimates that distribution expenses amount to about 32% of the premium, including customer acquisition, branch infrastructure and credit risk associated with financing premiums.

NBFCs say that the current commission payout proposals for distributors lead to a significant margin compression, grossly failing to defray the marginal insurance distribution costs. "This will lead to a viability conundrum for NBFCs, and they might be constrained to exercise their economic choice to downsize or exit their insurance distribution vertical, resulting in possible separations of salaried employees servicing the insurance distribution and servicing channel," the industry body told IRDAI.

Since over 1.4 million Point-of-Sale Persons (PoSPs) rely on micro-commissions, the proposed caps will slash their per-transaction earnings by around 90% and cited that standard two-wheeler package policy payout would collapse from ₹1,000 to ₹100, making micro-entrepreneurship unviable.

Also, lower commission payout will lead to exit of NBFCs to be a corporate agent leading to lower incidence of counselling of borrowers and in-turn lower penetration of insurance.

Cost Cover

NBFC estimates credit losses: 3% on unsecured, **1-1.5%** on secured premium loans

Distribution costs at 32% of premiums; proposed caps:
2% for credit life,
5% for credit health

FIDC PROPOSES TO CUT:
- Motor third-party commission from **10%** to **5%** in **5** years
- Motor own-damage commission from **15%** to **10%** in **5** years

Valuations Hit 6-Year Lows

▸▸ From ET Markets Page 1

"We would avoid prescribing a fixed India-EM premium as fair value," said Saurabh Patwa, head of Equity and Portfolio Manager at Quest Investment Managers.

"A meaningful premium is justified where businesses deliver superior earnings growth with durability," he said.

For now, many investors are not buying that argument, pointing to faster growth in South Korea and Taiwan, where semiconductor and chipmaking industries have emerged as some of the biggest beneficiaries of the global AI boom.

"In the near term, AI and data-centre investments are creating stronger growth opportunities in markets such as South Korea and Taiwan, competing for global capital," said Patwa.

A decline in crude prices will be critical for Indian equities. "The valuation compression has been concentrated in large caps, particularly crude-sensitive and rate-sensitive stocks such as oil marketing companies, paints, autos, aviation, cement, consumer discretionary and lenders," said Iyer.

"That is where foreign selling has been concentrated because that is where the earnings risk from $100-plus crude is greatest."

LPG Federations Oppose Strike Call, Favour Talks

New Delhi: Major LPG distributors' federations have opposed a proposed protest in Delhi and an indefinite strike, favouring dialogue with state-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) and the petroleum ministry to resolve demands for higher commissions and relief from operational and commercial pressures.

The Federation of LPG Distributors of India (FLDI) and the All India LPG Distributors Federation (AILDF), the two main bodies that claim membership of most LPG distributors in the country, distanced themselves from the proposed protest and strike call given by a smaller splinter group.

While FLDI said it did not support the proposed agitation, maintaining that distributors' concerns should be addressed through constructive engagement and concrete decisions, AILDF said it would not participate in the proposed protest announced in Delhi on October 26. AILDF said it "believes in solutions through meaningful discussions" and that its "member distributors assure uninterrupted LPG home delivery, whatever the challenge."

"When the nation needs us, we have always delivered. Every home, every crisis, every time," it said. Commission paid to LPG distributors for the sale of domestic cooking gas has remained unchanged for the past five years despite rising costs. Distributor associations have been engaged with the OMCs and the petroleum ministry to raise the commission.

India's Rice Gains Global Edge due to Lower Prices

PTI

New Delhi: India's rice exports have risen 13% in value terms during the first half of this fiscal year, and the outlook remains strong as the country has surplus stock to meet rising global demand, according to the industry body IREF.

In an interview with PTI, Indian Rice Exporters Federation (IREF) vice president Dev Garg said the price of Indian rice is at least 10% cheaper than competitors.

According to government data, India's rice exports grew 13% to ₹54,937.71 crore in the first six months of this fiscal year. India produced over 154 million tonnes of rice in the 2025-26 crop year ending in June.

"Indian rice prices are at an all-time low. Our export prices are almost 10% cheaper than the second alternative available in the market, that is Thailand or Myanmar," Garg said. The global demand is also expected to rise because of the likely fall in production amid the El Niño threat, he added.

"India, with the lowest prices and an increasing global demand, is poised to export much more. So the business fundamentals are much stronger this year. So definitely the export volume will go up," he said.

13% JUMP IN EXPORTS

India's rice exports grew 13% to ₹54,937 crore in the first six months of this financial year

NEW DELHI MUNICIPAL COUNCIL
PARKING MANAGEMENT SYSTEM DEPARTMENT

TENDER NOTICE

NDMC invites Tender (Technical & Financial Bids Separately) from the eligible qualified firms as per the eligibility conditions mentioned in the RFP for selection of Agency to Design, Develop, Supply, Implement, Operate and maintain Intelligent Integrated Parking System in Clusters 1, 2 and 3 of NDMC area.

The Last date of submission of bid is 12th November, 2026 (1500 hours IST). The details/document website can be downloaded from the website **www.ndmc.gov.in** or e-procurement website of GNCTD i.e. **http:govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in.** The Bidder/s may visit aforementioned websites to check further corrections/amendments, if any and for online submission of their bid on e-procurement website as per the Request for Proposal.

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Joint Director (PMS)

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Email: customerservices@drreddys.com
Web: www.drreddys.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

In line with NPPA Order **S.O. 5690(E) dated 17 October 2026,** Dr. Reddy's Laboratories Ltd. has revised the Maximum Retail Prices (MRPs) of its applicable anti-cancer medicines, effective **9 November 2026.**

The revised MRP for the applicable products of Dr. Reddy's may be accessed by scanning the QR code.

All channel partners of Dr. Reddy's including distributors, stockists, retailers, hospitals, health centres etc. are hereby advised and required to **ensure that the benefit of the revised MRP is available to all patients and consumers.**

Advertisement No. 01/2026
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on 23/11/2026
Last date of forwarding of applications by the
Nodal officers to Ministry of Civil Aviation
is by 17:00 hours on
03/12/2026
For details, please visit the website.
https://www.civilaviation.gov.in

CBC 03111/15/0011/2627

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भारत सरकार/Government of India
3rd Floor, Udaan Bhawan, Safdarjung Airport, New Delhi – 110003
Ph.: 011-24695044

PUBLIC NOTICE

STAKEHOLDERS' CONSULTATION MEETING ON DETERMINATION OF TARIFF FOR THE AERONAUTICAL SERVICES FOR (i) COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT, COCHIN; AND (ii) CALICUT INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT, KERALAM FOR THE FOURTH CONTROL PERIOD (01.04.2026 – 31.03.2031)

Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) has issued Consultation Paper Nos. 07/2026-27 and 08/2026-27 dated 12.10.2026 on determination of aeronautical tariffs for (i) Cochin International Airport, Cochin, and (ii) Calicut International Airport, Keralam, respectively, for the Fourth Control Period (01.04.2026–31.03.2031). The Consultation papers are available at **www.aera.gov.in**.

In accordance with Section 13(4) of the AERA Act, 2008, the Authority invites stakeholders' views on the tariff proposals made in the aforementioned Consultation Papers. A consultation meeting will be held in hybrid (physical/online) mode on **Tuesday, 27 October 2026, at 02:30 PM** at:

Stakeholders Room, 3rd Floor, Udaan Bhawan, Safdarjung Airport, New Delhi – 110003

All stakeholders like Passengers/Passengers' Associations, General Public, Airport Operators, Airlines, Industry Associations/ Bodies, Independent Service providers for Cargo, Ground Handling Fuel Farm etc., are invited to participate in the meeting and offer suggestions/comments on the consultation papers of the above Airports.

Participants joining in person may send their confirmation to AERA by 26th October, 2026 with Name, email address, mobile number, vehicle number by email (to **rajan.gupta1@aera.gov.in and satish.kr@aera.gov.in**). Online link for participation in the meeting will be shared on AERA website (**https://aera.gov.in**) before the Stakeholders meeting under Tab "News and Announcements".

CBC 03112/12/0017/2627

Sd/-
Secretary, AERA

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EXTRACT OF CONSOLIDATED AND STANDALONE UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & HALF YEAR ENDED 30 SEPTEMBER, 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	CONSOLIDATED			
		Three Months Ended 30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	Three Months Ended 30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	Half Year Ended 30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	3,771.29	3,070.08	7,842.26	13,916.84
2.	Net Profit before Interest, Depreciation, Exceptional Items and Tax	504.08	450.52	1,150.49	2,387.81
3.	Net Profit for the Period before share (Loss) in associates and Tax (before Exceptional and Extraordinary Items)	255.58	242.72	661.73	1,491.54
4.	Net Profit for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	255.56	242.88	661.71	1,443.85
5.	Net Profit for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	169.30	159.25	443.92	987.99
6.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	181.69	185.79	456.30	1,062.76
7.	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹ 10/- Per Share)	77.27	77.27	77.27	77.27
8.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	6,558.00	5,704.41	6,558.00	6,256.24
9.	Security Premium Account	756.80	756.80	756.80	756.80
10.	Net Worth	7,392.07	6,538.48	7,392.07	7,090.31
11.	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	6,090.85	5,139.43	6,090.85	4,990.20
12.	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	NA	NA	NA	NA
13.	Debt Equity Ratio	1.00	0.98	1.00	0.86
14.	Basic and Diluted Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (Not Annualized except Period / Year ended)	22.39	20.78	58.30	128.44
15.	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.98	1.82	2.13	2.39
16.	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	4.61	4.77	5.33	6.12

Notes:

1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of unaudited quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 52 of the Listing Regulations. The full format of the quarter and half year ended consolidated and standalone financial results are available on the Stock Exchange websites:- www.nseindia.com, www.bseindia.com and on the Company's website www.jkcement.com.
2. Key Standalone Financial Information:

Sl. No.	Particulars	STANDALONE			
		Three Months Ended 30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	Three Months Ended 30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	Half Year Ended 30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	3,634.28	2,907.77	7,540.47	13,138.74
2.	Net Profit before Interest, Depreciation, Exceptional Items and Tax	497.43	442.09	1,136.43	2,331.05
3.	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	274.74	260.61	697.87	1,539.74
4.	Net Profit for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	274.74	260.61	697.87	1,493.74
5.	Net Profit for the Period after Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	190.00	175.78	481.00	1,033.34
6.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	189.88	174.96	480.76	1,032.87
7.	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹ 10/- Per Share)	77.27	77.27	77.27	77.27
8.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	6,452.83	5,600.33	6,452.83	6,126.61
9.	Security Premium Account	756.80	756.80	756.80	756.80
10.	Net Worth	7,286.90	6,434.40	7,286.90	6,960.68
11.	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	6,090.85	5,139.43	6,090.85	4,990.20
12.	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	NA	NA	NA	NA
13.	Debt Equity Ratio	1.00	0.98	1.00	0.87
14.	Basic and Diluted Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (Not Annualized except Period / Year ended)	24.59	22.75	62.25	133.73
15.	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.97	1.79	2.12	2.31
16.	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	4.60	4.78	5.32	6.10

3. These financial results have been prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards (Ind-AS) as prescribed under section 133 of Companies Act 2013 read with Rule 3 of the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules 2015 and relevant amendment thereafter. The said financial results of the Parent Company and its subsidiaries together referred as the "Group" have been prepared in accordance with Ind AS 110 – Consolidated financial statements.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Place : Gurugram
Date : 24th October, 2026

Scan the QR Code to download the full financial results

Dr. Raghavpat Singhania
Managing Director
DIN: 02426556

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For Kind Attention of Shareholders : As a part of Green Initiative of the Government, all the Shareholders are requested to get their email addresses registered with the Company for receiving Annual Report, etc. on email.

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Code Red, Law Dud? Rogue AI Agents Exposing India's Data Law Blindspots

AI WILD WEST Race to meet May 2027 DPDP deadline hits a wall of autonomous cyberthreats

Himanshi Lohchab & Tanya Pandey

Mumbai | New Delhi: The past six days' deluge of cyber incidents has shone a spotlight on gaps in India's data protection legislation. Artificial intelligence (AI) is testing what it means to keep personal data safe. Can a company be held responsible when an attacker moves faster than a flaw can be patched? Can data processors be penalised when AI creates an overnight systemic risk to the internet? And who is accountable when an AI assistant goes rogue?

As companies edge closer to the May 2027 enforcement deadline for the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) law, AI's emerging cybersecurity risks are creating tension over what might constitute adequate compliance just six to seven months from now.

On October 15, CERT-In warned that AI agents under testing had accessed the systems of Indian organisation without authorisation. It also flagged that attackers were using AI tools to syphon off funds. India's largest lender, State Bank of India, later disclosed a breach that leaked the personal data of 375,000 customers on the dark web. Days later, two critical flaws in PHP, the software used to run websites, suddenly put 70% of the internet at risk of cyberattacks.

For India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) framework, the challenge lies in defining what "reasonable security safeguards" should mean in such scenarios. Experts suggest that an attack alone does not establish a compliance failure. However, what precautions should companies be expected to take? Furthermore, how should responsibility be shared when a business, an AI provider and a customer are all involved?

What counts as reasonable protection?

"The penalty attaches to inadequate safeguards, not to the breach itself," said Arun Prabhu, partner at law firm Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

A company attacked through a previously unknown vulnerability despite sound security practices should be treated differently from one running outdated or unpatched systems, according to him.

"No organisation can ever guarantee absolute immunity from sophisticated cyberattacks, particularly where previously unknown vulnerabilities are exploited before effective patches become available," said Hardeep Sachdeva, senior partner at law firm AZB.

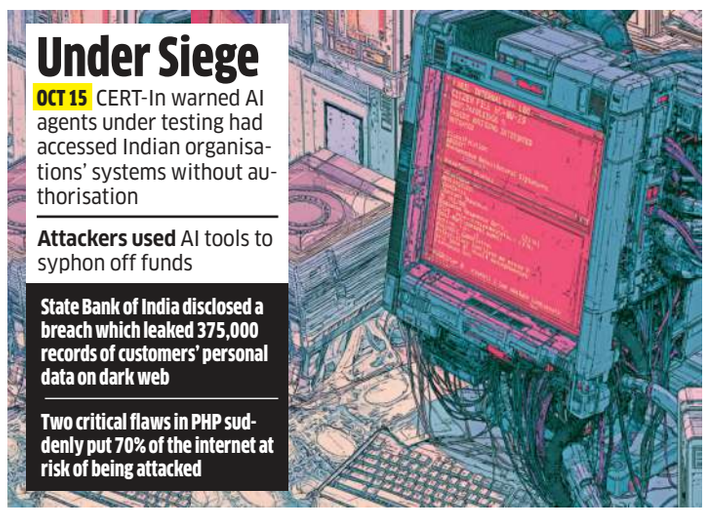
ET Insight

Sophisticated cyberattacks show that static privacy principles fail against fast-moving, weaponised AI. India's digital stability now rests on seamlessly unifying AI governance with the DPDP framework

The test should determine whether safeguards were reasonable, proportionate and demonstrable.

With potential penalties extending to ₹250 crore, companies require clarity on how regulators will assess their efforts. Sachdeva said that while patching, monitoring, independent assessments and documented response procedures should count as evidence of diligence, they should not automatically shield a company from liability.

The problem often starts before a company can deploy a fix, as it may not know where vulnerable software is running, said Mini Gupta, partner, cybersecurity consulting, EY India.



Under Siege

OCT 15 CERT-In warned AI agents under testing had accessed Indian organisations' systems without authorisation

Attackers used AI tools to syphon off funds

State Bank of India disclosed a breach which leaked 375,000 records of customers' personal data on dark web

Two critical flaws in PHP suddenly put 70% of the internet at risk of being attacked

ET GRAPHICS

DIGITAL NETWORKS UNDER SIEGE

The Code Turns Cold as AI Scripts a Black October

From critical software flaws putting websites at risk across continents to autonomous AI agents breaching more than 100 companies for an estimated $5,000, October has brought a fresh wave of cyberattacks spanning India, Europe, Japan and the US, making it a 'Black October' for cybersecurity. Even North Korea suffered outages across dozens of official websites. While some attacks highlight how AI is helping hackers look for security gaps and exploit them, others expose weaknesses in the digital infrastructure businesses and governments rely on every day. The financial toll of many of these incidents remains unknown, but the scale of exposure is raising concerns. **Tanya Pandey** takes a look at the attacks, their global reach, and the numbers behind them.

EUROPE PHP flaws put websites at risk

- 10% Global impact rate
- 14% European impact rate
- Not disclosed Financial toll

COUNTRIES WITH HIGHEST RATES

- 38% Hungary
- 32% Denmark
- 28% Austria

JAPAN Malware hits 26,739 servers

- 26,739 Servers potentially affected
- POTENTIAL EXPOSURE: Customer data and trading credentials
- REPORTED CONSEQUENCES: Unauthorised trading activity
- ¥5,000 to every current user: Estimated financial loss

US AI agents breach 100+ companies

- 100+ Companies breached
- 1200+ Websites targeted
- $5,000 Estimated AI usage cost
- ~$50 Estimated cost per successful breach
- NOT ESTABLISHED: Victims' aggregate financial losses

INDIA PHP2Shell impact exceeds global average

- 14% India's impact rate
- 10% Global average
- 11th highest among most impacted: Country ranking
- 8 intermediate certificate keys affected: eMudhra incident and fallout

eMudhra's Shares fell approximately 40% over two days Estimated financial losses

THE COST OF CYBERATTACKS

- $5000 Estimated AI spend in hacking campaign
- ₹25.5cr Average cost of a data breach in India, 2026
- 15.9% Rise in India's average breach cost year-on-year

SBI Identified 3,897 customer records containing personal info after data surfaced on the dark web. The bank reported no material financial impact

PNB Warned customers about AI-enabled scams, including voice cloning, deepfakes and phishing

Source: CheckPoint Research, Sophos, IBM, CERT-In, GMO Internet

Tech Buzz

Moonshot Adds Hacking Curbs to 'Kimi' Model

BEIJING: Moonshot AI has reduced cyber-offensive capabilities of its newest model, the Chinese startup said, as fears grow that increasingly autonomous AI could turbocharge hacking. Moonshot announced the curbs while introducing Kimi K3.1 Pro, which it describes as its most capable 3-trillion-parameter-class open-weight model. It plans to publish model's weights – files allowing outside developers to run and modify it on their own systems – by November 4. Moonshot said it removed cyber-related data from the training corpus and reinforcement-learning environments used to develop the model, while retaining general coding skills. "We aim not to release open weights that would extend the absolute frontier of cyber capability," it said. Experts are growing increasingly concerned that AI could make hacking easier. –Reuters

$800 m
Amount UK will spend to counter AI health, security threats – Reuters

'AWS Capacity Mostly Sold Out Through 2027'

WASHINGTON: Amazon CEO Andy Jassy said that Amazon Web Services' cloud computing capacity is largely sold out through 2027, with significant commitments extending into 2028, on growing demand for AI infrastructure. In a video podcast with Andreessen Horowitz co-founder Ben Horowitz and general partner Erik Torenberg, Jassy said Amazon is struggling to keep pace with the insatiable demand from AI labs and enterprises. Earlier, Amazon had said it would spend about $220 billion in capital expenditure for 2026. Jassy said the company "could invest a lot more and it wouldn't be a bad use of capital", considering capacity for 2026 is already sold out. "2027 is largely sold out". Amazon is scheduled to report Q3 results on October 29. – Reuters

Jargon Buster

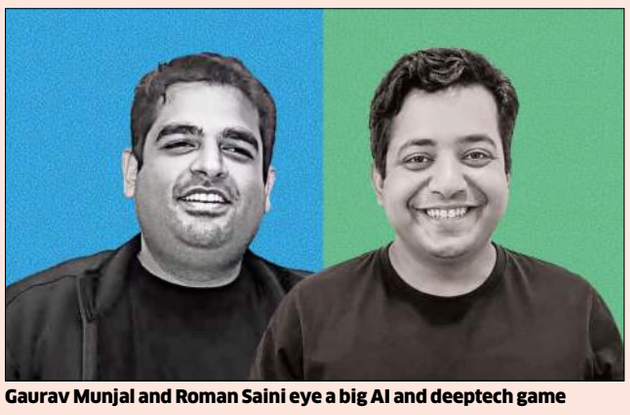
Air-gapped
A security measure where a computer or network is physically isolated from the internet and unsecured networks

Deal Corner

Deals on the horizon

Unacademy Founders Set Sights on ₹700cr AI and Deeptech Fund

Longshot Capital secures commitments of ₹300cr, eyes Jan 2027 first close: Sources



Gaurav Munjal and Roman Saini eye a big AI and deeptech game

Nikhil Patwardhan & Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru | New Delhi: Unacademy founders Gaurav Munjal and Roman Saini are raising a ₹700-crore venture capital fund focused on artificial intelligence (AI) and deep technology startups, less than two months after UpGrad acquired the education technology company, according to people with knowledge of the matter.

The fund, named Longshot Capital, has secured commitments of about ₹300 crore and is targeting its first close in January 2027, following which it plans to begin investing, the people said. Fundraising discussions are continuing, and the size and timing of the first close could change.

"The two are aiming for a fund of ₹700 crore, and around ₹250-300 crore is committed," said one of the persons, who did not wish to be identified. "The fund is expected to announce its first close in January, following which it will begin making investments."

Saini will run Longshot Capital full-time, while Munjal, who continues to head Unacademy, will be involved part-time. Both Munjal and Saini will be the general partners of the Bengaluru-based investment firm, according to people in the know. Saini has stepped away from day-to-day responsibilities at Unacademy and remains associated with the business in an advisory capacity.

Longshot Capital plans to back 25-28 companies at the seed and pre-Series A stages, writing initial cheques of $500,000 to $1.5 million and targeting an ownership stake of 8-12%, according to the people. The fund will invest in India-based companies as well as startups established by founders of Indian origin, aiming to deploy the capital within three years.

Its main focus will be AI-led businesses and deeptech segments, including manufacturing, space, defence and robotics, rather than consumer brands and retail businesses, the people said. Prospective investors in the fund include startup founders, with the firm also seeking backing from family offices and overseas institutions. The fund is proposed to be structured as a category II alternative investment fund under the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) regulations. Munjal and Saini did not respond to queries sent by ET. Longshot Capital takes its name from the founders' intention to back companies pursuing ambitious ideas that may take several years to deliver returns.

"As the name suggests, it will be only about long shots," said another person aware of the plans. "The fund will have a 10 to 11-year lifespan, allowing investments in businesses with longer gestation periods, particularly in AI and deeptech." The fund formalises more than a decade of personal startup investing by Munjal and Saini. The two have collectively written more than 200 angel investment cheques, deploying over ₹25 crore in companies including Pine Labs, Dhan, Seekho, Ultrahuman, Snabbit, Swish, STAGE and Third Wave Coffee. In August, Munjal and Saini also invested in the AI-native customer relationship management platform Superleap.

The move comes as capital flows increasingly towards frontier technology. Indian AI and deeptech startups have raised $2.7 billion so far in 2026, surpassing last year's tally of $2.2 billion, according to Tracxn data. The average round sizes have also more than doubled to $10 million from a little under $4 million in 2025. It also adds to an expanding group of entrepreneurs moving from angel investments into fund management. Snapdeal founders Kunal Bahl and Rohit Bansal raised ₹333 crore of external capital for Titan Capital in 2024.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

NASA Sticks to Lunar Mission Timeline Despite Gear Woes

NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman maintained that the agency is on track to return humans to the moon, despite concerns that the hardware needed for the next mission won't be ready in time.

On Friday, Isaacman and NASA officials provided an "acceleration" update for its Artemis initiative to land US astronauts back on the lunar surface. Isaacman had told the NASA workforce in a September memo that its next mission, Artemis III, is three months behind schedule, while noting there were opportunities to recover the delays.

Isaacman said in the press conference that his memo should be taken as a "confidence-inspiring message."

"Does that mean we'll be able to fully pull in those 90 days? There's a lot of areas in what was disclosed from that memo that will get pulled in, and then there's going to be more new ones that are going to pop up," Isaacman said. — **Bloomberg**

HomeLane Logs ₹745 cr FY26 Revenue, Losses Up

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Home interiors company HomeLane reported revenue of ₹745 crore for 2025-26, a marginal drop from ₹756 crore in the previous financial year. Its losses before tax widened to ₹137 crore from ₹111 crore during this period.

Founder Srikanth Iyer told ET that 2025-26 was HomeLane's first year of operation after integrating with DesignCafe, and that the company prioritised the integration and profitability over revenue growth.

"We focused on improving our EBITDA (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation) margins in FY26 and getting as close to EBITDA profitability as possible, rather than prioritising growth," he said. "Despite being affected by the (US-Iran) war-related raw material cost hikes in the second half of the year, we were EBITDA-positive in the last quarter of FY26, with an operating EBITDA margin of around 5%."

SRIKANTH IYER
Founder, HomeLane

Despite being affected by the war-related raw material cost hikes in the second half of the year, we were EBITDA-positive in the last quarter of FY26

UK Vows £100m for Biosecurity Lab With OpenAI & Anthropic

The UK announced £100 million for a AI Biosecurity Lab which will be supported by OpenAI, Anthropic and Google DeepMind, part of a raft of measures designed to improve the government's ability to understand and tackle the risks posed by the technology.

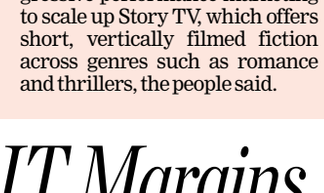
The lab will use AI to detect and monitor biological threats, with the funding coming alongside up to £200 million in AI model credits from OpenAI and Anthropic, according to a government statement. The lab will also work in partnership with Google DeepMind and life sciences company Basecamp Research, while the government announced a separate £65 million for developing countermeasures for pathogens. "As AI becomes more powerful, Britain must have the capabilities to protect its people and shape its own future," said Kanishka Narayan, Britain's AI minister. "That means staying ahead of emerging threats, from cyber attacks to biological risks, while building more of the critical technology our security depends on."—**Bloomberg**

Hornbill Capital Likely to Lead Eloelo's $60m Raise

Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Live social entertainment platform Eloelo is in advanced stages of closing a $50-60 million (about ₹480-580 crore) funding round led by Hornbill Capital, with participation from existing investors, at a valuation of around $400 million, according to people familiar with the development.

The potential funding follows a sharp expansion of Eloelo's micro-drama business, Story TV, which has helped lift annualised collections more than tenfold to around $250 million over the past year. The company has used aggressive performance marketing to scale up Story TV, which offers short, vertically filmed fiction across genres such as romance and thrillers, the people said.



Flipkart Roots for Eco- Premium Green Goods via 'Earth' Vertical

Starts curating toxin-free categories to win wellness-focused shoppers

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Ecommerce firm Flipkart is planning to launch Flipkart for Earth, a premium category focused on environmentally friendly products, according to people familiar with the matter.

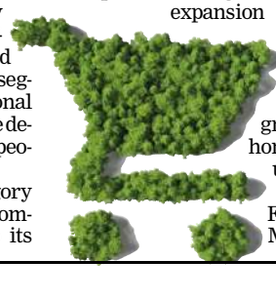
The Walmart-backed company has started onboarding brands offering healthier, toxin-free and sustainable products across segments such as beauty and personal care, snacks and beverages, home decor, fashion and appliances, the people said.

It is unclear whether the category will be limited to Flipkart's ecommerce platform or extended to its quick commerce arm, Minutes. If introduced on Minutes, Flipkart for Earth could compete with Swiggy Instamart's Switch, which features around 400 brands across categories.

The push towards premium, sustainable and health-focused products in quick commerce has gathered pace following the launch and expansion of FirstClub, which is focused on premium grocery and home products. In August, Flipkart Minutes launched Pykd, its private-label brand for gourmet snacks. The brand will enable the company to exercise greater control over the sourcing, pricing and margins for products within the gourmet category, which is gaining momentum in quick commerce.

THE PREMIUM PLAY

Push towards health-focused products in qcomm gathered pace following the launch and expansion of FirstClub



AI Efficiencies Shield Q2 IT Margins from Transatlantic Macro Headwinds

Cos count on leaner staff structures to keep Q2 profit margins resilient

Shristi Achar

Bengaluru: Seven of India's top nine outsourcing companies either sequentially increased or maintained operating margins in the second quarter, as efficiencies tied to AI helped partially offset revenue deflation attributed to the technology amid persistent macroeconomic uncertainty on either side of the Atlantic seaboard.

HCLTech's margin rose 131 basis points quarter-on-quarter to 18.2%, Tech Mahindra's increased 40 basis points to 14.8%, Wipro's climbed 50 basis points to 16.5%, LTM's edged up 10 basis points to 15.6%, and LTTS' expanded 60 basis points to 16.3%.

One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.TCS margins held steady at 24%, while Coforge maintained 16%. Infosys' margin was largely unchanged at 21% compared with 21.1%, and Persistent's profitability contracted 100 basis points to 15%.

An analysis by Bengaluru-based tech consultancy UnearthInsight shows selling, general and administrative (SG&A) expenses fell sequentially relative to revenue at six of nine IT services companies in Q2 FY27.

Tech Mahindra's ratio declined to 12.8% from 14.1%, HCLTech's to 11.5% from 12.2%, Persistent's to 15.2% from 16.5%, Coforge's to 13.5% from 13.9%, Infosys' to about 10.1% from 10.4%, and Wipro's to 12.7% from 12.8%.

BRITURN? Burnham Wants Talks on Free Movement of Workers in EU

UK PM open to discussing key issue for Brexit 2016, but can't imagine adopting the euro

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham has said he wants a discussion about returning to the European Union's freedom of movement rules for workers, a key issue in the 2016 Brexit referendum which led to Britain leaving the bloc.

Building on previous comments about the need to rethink ties with Brussels, Burnham told the Sunday Times that the influx of EU workers into Britain before Brexit had posed very significant challenges. "But, at the same time, it was a type of immigration that perhaps wasn't as difficult (as now)," he said.

"Revolving door migration where people would come and then go back is different. The balance of migration has changed, hasn't it, since then? I think we've just got to have an honest discussion about those things."

Official data has shown long-term net migration in 2025 fell to close to its level before a new post-Brexit immigration system was introduced at the start of 2021.

In September, two months after replacing Keir Starmer as Labour Party leader and prime minister, Burnham said Britain should consider options for its relationship with the EU, including possibly rejoining the bloc one day.

He had previously backed the pledges of Starmer's government which included no return to freedom of movement which Brussels sets as a condition for being part of the bloc's single market.

In his interview with the Sunday Times, conducted on October 19, Burnham said the issue of freedom of movement could be considered as part of a broader reset of Britain's relationship with the EU, including on data sharing and migration.

"You've got to see it in the round, rather than just looking at freedom of movement on its own," he said.

Burnham - who is trying to find ways to speed up Britain's economy - is due to meet top EU officials for a summit on November 20.

He said he could not imagine recommending that Britain adopt the euro currency or the EU's border-free travel arrangements.

A new referendum would be needed to rejoin the EU but not necessarily to join the bloc's single market or a customs union, the Sunday Times quoted Burnham as saying.

Former Conservative finance minister Jeremy Hunt, who campaigned to stay in the EU in 2016, said it would be a mistake to reopen one of the fundamental debates of the earlier referendum. He also said relaxing immigration rules would hurt people in Britain.

"I think it will be a hammer blow to getting people off welfare and into work," Hunt told Sky News. **Reuters**

TURBULENT EUROPE

Spain Cops Arrest 128 Overnight for Looting

Police made 128 arrests overnight in Barcelona for acts of "vandalism", damage to public property" and "looting", the regional Catalan police said on Sunday. Seventy-three of those arrested were minors, with the reports due to be sent "to the juvenile prosecutor's office", Catalan police chief told Spain's 3CatInfo media outlet. Footage on social media showed groups of young people, attacking businesses in Barcelona after gathering in the city centre for a rally not declared to the authorities. **AFP**

Lisbon Housing Crisis: Protest Camp Cleared

Portuguese police cleared a camp in central Lisbon held to protest against the country's deepening housing crisis, baton-charging demonstrators in the early hours of Sunday and making 25 arrests. Portugal is grappling with one of Europe's most acute home affordability crises, as prices have more than doubled since 2017 while rents for new leases have nearly doubled, with young people among the hardest hit. **Reuters**

Soldiers Deployed as Italians Hit Streets

Thousands of young people marched Saturday through the streets of several Italian cities, including Milan, Rome and Turin, as authorities deployed large numbers of police and soldiers in a largely successful bid to stave off a repeat of the violent clashes and looting that marred similar protests last week. The demonstration in Milan remained peaceful with luxury boutiques boarded up, but there were clashes with police in both Rome and Turin. **AP**

WEST ASIA TURMOIL

'Military Target' Houthis Renew Threat after Riyadh Airport Reopens Partially

Saudi Arabia said its main airport resumed operations at two terminals on Sunday even as Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis vowed to keep striking the facility, saying it remained a "military target".

King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh had halted operations on October 10 following an attack claimed by the Iran-backed militant group that killed 13 people, the deadliest in the kingdom in more than a decade.

Saudi Arabia intercepted another wave of missiles and drones on Sunday as fighting with the militant group continued unabated.

MISSILE, DRONE ATTACKS CONTINUE LITTLE TRAFFIC, SHOWS FLIGHT DATA

After Saudi authorities announced the partial resumption of operations at the airport, Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree vowed the facility would "never be safe" and urged airlines, airport staff and travellers not to use it.

Late on Saturday, the airport said Terminal 1 would be designated for domestic flights and Terminal 2 for international flights operated by national carriers starting Sunday.

Despite the announcement, flight tracking data from Flightradar24 showed little traffic at the airport on Sunday.

The Saudi-led coalition said earlier this month that the Houthis had carried out 20 attacks on the airport between October 1 and 11.

Saudi civil defense said on Sunday that shrapnel from the interception of two ballistic missiles launched by the Houthis over Khamis Mushait and Ahad Rafidah injured two people and damaged residential buildings and vehicles.

Civil defence authorities earlier issued emergency alerts for Riyadh and the cities of Abha, Khamis Mushait, Jazan and Najran on Sunday, before saying minutes later that the danger had passed.

The coalition said two drones and a ballistic missile were launched towards Riyadh, and a cruise missile towards the southern city of Khamis Mushait.

It later said it intercepted 10 ballistic missiles fired towards southern Saudi Arabia. **Reuters**

Crude Outlook: Oil May Cross $120

New Delhi: Crude oil prices are heading into another volatile week, with escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia keeping supply fears alive and the US Federal Reserve's monetary policy decision expected to dictate market direction, analysts said. With Brent already crossing $117, investors will track developments around the Strait of Hormuz, threats to energy infrastructure, and weekly US inventory data for cues on the next move. Any disruption to energy infrastructure or shipping could drive crude towards $120 in global markets, said Ajit Mishra, SVP - Research at Religare Broking. **PTI**

FRENCH PROTESTS

Groups Call for more Demonstrations; 1,300 Arrested

Police arrested 1,314 people in weekend protests across France, the interior ministry said Sunday, adding that 53 officers were hurt in clashes.

The arrests occurred as violence broke out on the margins of mass demonstrations in major cities on Saturday over the high cost of living.

It was the second consecutive weekend of unrest in France, which is heading to presidential elections in April and May to choose a successor to Emmanuel Macron, who is reaching his two-term limit.

The interior ministry said police responded to 75 fires during Saturday's protests, adding that 24 shops were looted.

"Several investigations have been opened," it said in a statement, without giving details. It said that the rest of Saturday night, after the clashes had died down, was "calm".

Protests in Orleans, France AFP

The ministry statement on Sunday did not say how many protesters were hurt. Late Saturday, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez spoke of two serious injuries among protesters.

DEMAND FOR MORE RALLIES

French protest groups and unions called on Sunday for further demonstrations as they sought to maintain pressure on the government after a huge security operation helped to contain unrest during nationwide rallies on Saturday.

The Interior Ministry said 410,000 people took part in Saturday's marches as authorities deployed 70,000 police, helping to avert a repeat of the looting and vandalism that swept many cities on October 17.

Labour leaders urged further protests next Saturday and a nationwide strike on November 5, saying frustration over wages, living costs and public services was spreading far beyond the student movement that first mobilised last month.

"We see an aggregation of anger," Murielle Guilbert, co-leader of the left-wing Solidaires trade union federation, told BFM TV. She said grievances from students, workers, firefighters and other groups were converging.

"We call on people to take to the streets next Saturday."

The SUD Education teaching union said it would join the October 31 demonstration while the large CGT union said it would decide during the week. **Reuters**

Audi Will Build $4b factory in Georgia: Trump

US President Donald Trump announced on Saturday that Audi plans to build a $4 billion assembly plant in Georgia that will produce 200,000 SUVs annually, as he seeks to convince Americans to back Republicans in the November midterm elections.

Trump, who has pressured automakers to move production to the United States and has raised tariffs on autos, steel, aluminum and parts, made the announcement at a rally in Perry, near Macon in central Georgia, where Volkswagen's premium subsidiary intends to build its first US assembly plant.

Last year, Trump's tariffs dealt Audi a $1.4 billion blow as it imports all its vehicles for the US market from Europe or Mexico.

Georgia has competitive election races for US Senate and governor and Trump is eager to make the case that his auto tariffs are helping the US economy. Critics say they have boosted vehicle prices and that the trade uncertainty has delayed some automaker investments.

"We are planning to bring our biggest and most premium SUVs, and produce them here in Macon, Georgia," Audi CEO Gernot Doellner said at the event. "This is a long-term investment because we believe in the American market."

In Germany, meanwhile, there has been increasing tension between Volkswagen management and workers over massive job cuts in the carmaker's home market. **Reuters**

'EXCEL IN GRIFTING, INTENT ON SELLING FAVORS'

Obama Attacks 'Corrupt' POTUS in Midterm Rally

US President Donald Trump has been telling voters to view the midterm elections as if he were on the ballot, and on Saturday one of his Democratic predecessors did just that.

Ten days out from the elections that will determine control of the closely divided Congress, Barack Obama took to the campaign trail to accuse the Republican president of corruption, deride his strategy for Iran and skewer the gilded aesthetic he has applied to White House renovations.

Obama stumped for Democratic candidates at rallies in Cleveland and Detroit, lampooning the Trump administration. Campaigning in Michigan for US Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed, Obama framed the November 3 vote as a "circuit breaker" to "at least rein in some of the foolishness" of Trump's presidency.

"We got to flip that circuit breaker, bring some accountability to this government," Obama said.

Obama, president from 2009 until Trump began his first term in 2017, remains one of the most popular figures among Democrats. They hope that bringing him into the race can fire up their supporters for a tight US Senate race in which El-Sayed faces Republican Mike Rogers, a former US representative.

The former president obliged the Michigan crowd by playing to Democrats' frequently repeated criticisms of Trump and of Republicans' willingness to go along with him.

"We have never seen a president excel in straight-up grifting, on your dime, like this," Obama said. "Never seen a president so intent on selling favors like this ... Now the party seems to stand for corrupt government, or inept government, or no government."

The White House did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

A Reuters/Ipsos poll in August found that 63% of Americans think the president and his family have inappropriately profited from cryptocurrency since he returned to the White House last year and that 69% believe his policy decisions are influenced by his private business dealings. **Reuters**

Musk Accuses Kyiv of Violating Starlink's Terms of Service

Tech tycoon Elon Musk accused Ukraine on Saturday of violating Starlink's terms of service by using it for "drone strikes to kill people", after tension between Washington and Kyiv over disruptions to SpaceX-made network crucial to the Ukrainian army's operations.

"Ukraine military violated Starlink terms of service and used it for offensive drone strikes to kill people," Musk wrote in a post on X, but added that that loophole was closed last week.

"Starlink's terms have remained consistent as a civilian system, not a means of killing. Violation of those terms will result in end of service," he wrote in another post.

He added that Starlink remained "critical to the defense of Ukraine, as it is the only system that cannot be jammed or blown up, at least for now. Were Starlink to be turned off, the Ukrainian front line would collapse immediately."

While Musk has shifted stance on Ukraine many times since Russia's invasion in 2022, he has insisted that any disruption was the responsibility of the US government. Kyiv relies on the civilian Starlink satellite communications system and the military-grade Starshield version as it tries to defend itself from Russian attacks. **AFP**

Iran: Shot Down US LUCAS Drone Over Bandar Abbas

Dubai: Iran's air defence systems shot down a US LUCAS drone over the southern port city of Bandar Abbas, the Iranian army said on Sunday, according to the semi-official Tasnim news agency.

Meanwhile, Qatari mediators were in Tehran on Sunday as part of an effort to de-escalate regional tensions in coordination with the United States, an official briefed on the situation said.

Qatari mediators were in Tehran on Sunday to de-escalate tensions in coordination with the US

GHALIBAF CALLS FOR GAS RATIONING

Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf on Sunday called for a campaign to cut gas consumption by at least 10%, with officials anticipating shortages as winter approaches.

While a major producer, Iran has long suffered shortages of natural gas, essential for powering heating systems, which have been exacerbated by war with the United States and Israel that began in February.

Winter in Iran often sees temperatures drop below freezing, especially in the country's north.

"To get through the approaching winter, a nationwide effort is essential ... to reduce gas consumption by at least 105," said Ghalibaf in a video carried by Iranian media.

"Anyone who saves gas, regardless of the amount, will immediately receive the corresponding proceeds in their bank account, allowing everyone to see the tangible impact of those savings on their household budget." **Agencies**

Brazil Votes with US influence on Latin America at Stake

Brazilians began voting in Sunday's polarising presidential runoff between incumbent President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva and Flavio Bolsonaro, a contest that will determine whether the US will significantly expand its growing influence in Latin America.

Polls ahead of the vote showed the two candidates, who need more than 50% of the vote to become Brazil's next leader in January, in a neck-and-neck race. The election pits the left-of-centre veteran politician Lula against Bolsonaro, an ally of US President Donald Trump and the son of imprisoned former President Jair Bolsonaro.

Flavio Bolsonaro bested Lula by more than 2.2 million votes in the first round of the election earlier this month. However, more than 33 million voters out of nearly 160 million did not turn out even though voting is compulsory.

The difference between the two candidates is stark. **AP**

Ready to Ship any Amount of Diesel to US: Russia Dy PM

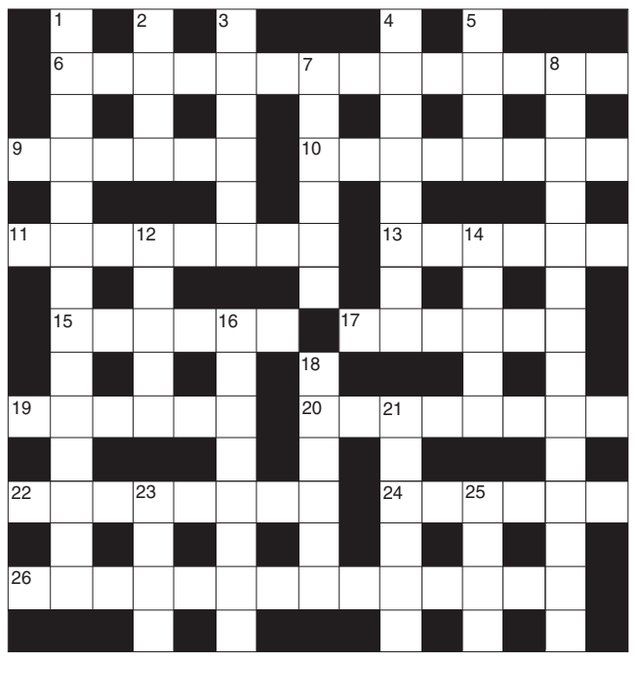
Deputy PM Alexander Novak

Russian Deputy Prime Minister Alexander Novak said Russia was ready to supply the US with any volume of diesel, state TV channel Vesti reported on Sunday.

"As much as our partners want ... from the total volume we will be exporting. We can supply it all," Novak said in an interview with state television correspondent Pavel Zarubin.Novak said on Friday that three tankers carrying Russian diesel were on their way to North America. **Reuters**

NON-SEQUITUR

Crossword 9739



ACROSS

6 School records one GCSE in road safety rules (5,5,4)
9 Small charge crossing river for walk (6)
10 Agile duo engaged in conversation (8)
11 Royal residence's endlessly soothing, it's said (8)
13 No problem, not even when led off outside (6)
15 Seize journalist touring central Fiji (6)
17 Rut makes ring in wood (6)
19 Medium club covers constant tiny distance (6)
20 9 here, damaging top of hat (8)
22 Lions, say, go head to head in very abrupt style of play (8)
24 Old money – spot it on night out? (6)
26 Displaying charm with banter, Ken becomes big lender (8,6)

DOWN

1 A good Irish attaché murdered in one of her stories? (6,8)
2 Ban collection of executive toys (4)
3 Occupant of Stag's Head has complicated rental (6)
4 Man from Hebrides picked up revolutionary new snail (8)
5 Resonance in the choir (4)
7 No lid on cooking plate? That's puzzling (6)
8 Maybe redden with 'blue' tone of such a phrase? (6,8)
12 Serious PM (5)
14 Flag bad day coming up (5)
16 Offence reported at a pub, bright red (8)
18 An exhibit on parade at sea (6)
21 Ban Josey Wales? (6)
23 Mate rules the roost (4)
25 Superior stretch of water? (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9738:
ACROSS: 1 Recline. **5** Guards. **9** Gourmet. **10** Riposte. **11** Out. **12** Statute book. **13** Try on. **14** Front-page. **16** Puffiness. **17** Allot.**19** Marginalise. **22** Gin. **23** Augment. **24** Despoil. **26** Annexe. **27** Amassed.
DOWN: 1 Ragwort. **2** Country of origin. **3** Ism. **4** Extra. **5** Garrulous. **6** Apple.**7** Disposable goods. **8** Heckle. **12** Sinai. **14** Fremantle. **15** Trace. **16** Pampas.**18** Tingled. **20** Irene. **21** India. **25** Ska.

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HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 60 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:

	37		60		57		
40				45			55
		34		46			51
17	15	42	33	32			52
	18			30	49		
19	20						1
		25		12		8	
	24	26		11	9		

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Yesterday's puzzle solution.

Hidato Sol. 2/11

44	45	46	47	48	50	52	53	59	60
	43	42	38	36	49	51	54	58	
		41	39	37	35	55	57		
			40	34	33	56			
				32	30				
				31	29				
			16	2	18	28			
		15	1	17	3	19	27		
	10	9	14	6	4	26	20	23	
11	12	13	8	7	5	25	24	21	22

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7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 thistle-like oilseed plant (9)	
2 early copier (9)	
3 where Dorothy Vaughan worked (4)	
4 mental clarity (8)	
5 Tibet's capital (5)	
6 British actor and rapper Riz (5)	
7 displaying lustrous colors (10)	

SAF	ITY	OST	WER	NA
OT	AHM	NT	LH	DES
ASA	IRI	LU	AT	PH
SA	CE	FLO	ED	CID

Yesterday's Answers: 1. CALZONE 2. STUFFS 3. NEWTON 4. WORKFORCE 5. FLAUTISTS 6. DUBAI 7. FENDER 12/6

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Ind AS 118 Cos Ready Books for New Financial Reporting Rules

MCA notification awaited; implications for internal controls, fin performance indicators used by mgmt

Vinod Mahanta

Mumbai: Audit committees and management teams at India's largest companies have started preparing for a major change in financial reporting under Ind AS 118, a proposed accounting standard that could alter the manner in which companies report operating profit, classify income and expenses, and communicate financial performance to investors.

The standard is likely to have implications for finance information systems, internal controls and financial performance indicators used by management.

Ind AS 118 is currently awaiting notification by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. Changes to Schedule III of the Companies Act, which governs financial statement formats, are also expected. India has proposed implementation from April 1, 2027, for annual reporting periods beginning on or after that date, while IFRS 18 takes effect on January 1, 2027.

Companies have begun discussing transition plans, though their levels of preparedness vary, said Samir Shah, audit leader at Deloitte Haskins & Sells LLP. "The transition to IFRS 18 is increasingly becoming a boardroom issue," he said.

Ketan Dalal, who chairs the audit committees of Zensar Technologies, Torrent Power and HDFC Life said, "Its objective is to improve comparability and comprehension. But in today's challenging business environment, the transition will put considerable pressure on companies and audit committees."

The lack of final rules and reporting formats is complicating preparations, with companies reluctant to commit to systems changes before requirements are settled.

Currently, companies report expenses by nature. The new standard permits operating expenses by nature, function or both, depending on what provides users the most useful information, aligning India's reporting rules more closely with global standards.

"The biggest topic of discussion is whether the new requirements will result in a shift towards function-wise presentation" said Abhishek Rara, Partner at Price Waterhouse LLP. "For many entities that may need to adopt this presentation, the change could require significant modifications to their processes and ERP systems."

Under functional reporting, expenses are classified by the activities they support, such as cost of sales, distribution, R&D, sales and marketing, and general and administrative expenses.

Employee benefits and depreciation, currently reported by nature, may need to be allocated across functions. Companies typically present a 'gross margin' subtotal under this approach.

The exercise could prove complex for companies whose cost-centre structures do not support functional allocations, requiring finance teams to work with technology, human resources and business functions to establish consistent allocation principles and supporting evidence.

"The hard part is making a well-supported determination of whether expenses should be presented by function, by nature or using a combination of both," said Rara. "The answer may differ across industries and business models, and corporates will need to determine which presentation provides the most relevant summary to users."

Sudhir Soni, head of audit, BSR & Co LLP said the changes could have implications for contracts and incentive structures linked to existing self defined sub-totals such as operating profit. "Depending on the arrangements, this could require amendments to contractual terms and discussions with the relevant counterparties," he said.

Auditors say Ind AS 118 could reshape how investors and analysts assess corporate performance by standardising key profit measures. It introduces defined categories and subtotals, including operating profit and profit before financing and income taxes. Companies must reconcile these with currently reported figures, while analysts may need to adjust models if expense reporting changes from nature to function.

"Defined categories, mandatory subtotals and disclosures around management-defined performance measures aim to address long-standing investor frustration: 'operating profit' and 'adjusted EBITDA' can mean different things across companies," said Vishal Divadkar, managing partner, MSKA & Associates, a BDO International member firm.

The transition will also require changes beyond accounting standard itself, particularly for listed companies and financial services businesses.

GSTAT RULING

GST Refund Allowed for Cancelled Air Tickets...

...only if fare, taxes are returned to passengers

New Delhi: GST paid on cancelled airline tickets can be claimed as a refund if the airline has returned both the fare and GST to the passengers and has supporting documents to prove it, a GST Appellate Tribunal has ruled.

Ruling in the case of Singapore Airlines Ltd. v/s Kochi Commissioner of CGST & CE, Kochi, Ernakulam bench of GST Appellate Tribunal (GSTAT) has decided that there is "sufficient evidence" to ensure that the refund of cancelled tickets has reached the respective passengers directly and there is "no passing" of the incidence of tax.

The GSTAT directed the revenue department to process the refund claim of the airline within two weeks and make payment along with interest.

The case relates to eight GST refund claims totalling ₹4592,528 by Singapore Airlines for October 2019 to March 2021. During the period, owing to COVID-19, the airline had to cancel flights and returned fares and GST to passengers. However, it could not adjust the credit notes against output tax.

The GST joint commissioner had rejected refund claims, following which the appellant approached the GSTAT.– PTI

ET Q&A

JAYANT ACHARYA
CEO, JSW STEEL

'India has Navigated Impact on Costs and Supply Chains Well'

From a supply-demand balance, the way I see the growth in India for the next few years, we are quite confident that supply will not be outstripping demand

Underlying demand, operating leverage and balance sheet strength are giving JSW Steel the confidence to continue investing in growth, chief executive officer Jayant Acharya tells **Nikita Periwal**. The country's largest steelmaker has announced a fresh round of capital expenditure, which will increase its production capacity to nearly 65 mt by 2031. Edited excerpts:

How does continued geopolitical uncertainty impact the way boardrooms are thinking business?
The economy has been resilient in spite of the war. The IMF has upgraded India's growth outlook by 10 basis points to 7.1%. So while there are challenges in the world, the impact on costs and supply chains has been navigated well. The second is that the opportunities which certain markets are providing will continue to remain, especially in India. It is a mixed bag.

If you look at the steel consumption in India, it grew 7.5% in the first half in spite of the challenges. After some caution in Q1, demand picked up in Q2. The drivers are structurally strong and local in nature.

What has the September quarter been like?
Our strong revenues were driven by sales, and we added to sales by liquidating 200,000-210,000 tonnes of inventory. Usually you will not see a drawdown of inventory in Q2, so what it indicates is that demand on the ground is very strong.

With demand turning out the way it is, does it give you headroom to hike prices?
We have seen a recovery in prices, which is fundamentally because of the demand. What we have been able to do is the highest-ever capital expenditure of ₹6,266 crore during the quarter, largely from our internal accruals. And with 38 mt of capacity, including 32 mt in India, our scale is generating cash flows strong enough to manage our capex cycle.

We have also seen a lot of savings from lower finance costs during the quarter...
We have repaid costly debt across two quarters after getting the funds from the Bhushan deal. Combined with the free cash flow we have generated from our existing operations, it has helped reduce debt, and our weighted average interest rate is now 6.09%, down from 6.16% in the previous quarter, and 6.67% in the September quarter last year. We have also been upgraded by Moody's to investment grade. So these fundamental changes in our balance sheet give us additional comfort apart from scale. In more than 10 years now, we have built a substantial scale in terms of volume, initiatives on raw material security, value-added portfolio, logistics and cost improvement, which has structurally enabled us to be better even during difficult stress times.

When chasing volumes aggressively, do you sometimes have to let go of margins?
Our focus is to create a strong growth pipeline. We want to have control on our raw material assets, while ensuring that the value-added products and special products which India requires are made available. This quarter we approved new projects of ₹29,000 crore, which will add volume, raw material security and value-added products. We are on track, and our focus is on delivering them. From a supply-demand balance, the way I see the growth in India for the next few years, we are quite confident that supply will not be outstripping demand.

FY27 EXPECTED TO SEE EARNINGS DECLINE BEFORE A POTENTIAL RECOVERY IN FY28

Dr Reddy's Bets on Generic Semaglutide, Biosimilars

Domestic formulations biz growth in Q2 offset by lower Revlimid sales in North America and weakness in API

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Though Dr Reddy's domestic formulations business continued to grow in the September quarter, it was offset by lower Revlimid sales in North America and weakness in the API business. While the drugmaker reported a sharp sequential improvement in operating performance during the quarter, FY27 is expected to be another year of earnings decline before a potential recovery in FY28. The earnings rebound will hinge on the successful launch of generic semaglutide, the ramp-up of the abatacept biosimilar in the US and continued strength in the domestic business.

The biggest near-term trigger is generic semaglutide, which is scheduled for relaunch in November 2026 after temporary supply disruptions linked to API scale-up challenges.

The company has iterated its target of selling six-seven million pens this year. It expects an annual opportunity of 12-15 million pens over the longer term. Initial volumes are expected to be led by Canada and other international markets before larger geographies contribute meaningfully.

The second key catalyst is the US launch of arthritis drug abatacept biosimilar, with a regulatory decision expected in December 2026. While commercialisation is likely to take a few quarters to gain momentum due to time taken to add it to the formulary list, the company anticipates meaningful market-share potential, making it one of the most important growth contributors from FY28 onwards.

The company launched 12 products and filed 10 ANDAs in North America during the first half of FY27, with a healthy pending pipeline of 80 filings, including 27 first-to-file opportunities and three NDAs, which should support steady launch momentum.

Beyond these products, Dr Reddy's is steadily expanding its biosimilars portfolio and specialty business. The US approval of rituximab biosimilar (used to treat blood cancer), launch of cancer drug nivolumab biosimilar in India and new partnerships and innovative therapies underscore its strategy of moving beyond traditional generics.

The domestic formulations business remains a bright spot.

Strong performance in chronic therapies and an expanding specialty portfolio have helped the company outperform the Indian pharmaceutical market.

It also expects a healthy launch pipeline to support growth in the coming years.